A COMPARATIVE SPIRITUAL STUDY

Adiyogi and the First Man

From Kailash to Calvary



Neelam P.J. Pradeep Jesudas, B.Th

JAI BHIM EDUCATIONAL CHARITABLE TRUST

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English edition, translated from the Tamil original *Adiyogiyum Aadi Manithanum*.

Scripture quotations follow the King James Version, lightly modernised in places.

This book is a respectful comparative study; it has no intention of belittling any tradition.

Preface

Two Mountains, One Search

Everyone born on Tamil soil has probably grown up hearing stories of two mountains. One is snow-covered Kailash, where, as the temple singers (oduvars) of our towns sing, Lord Shiva sits enthroned with Uma. The other is a small hill outside Jerusalem called Calvary, where Jesus Christ was crucified, as our church bells remind us every Good Friday. Thousands of kilometres separate these two mountains, yet both try to answer the same human question: "Who am I? Where did I come from? How will I return to God?"

When my earlier book, *From the Holy Bible to the Holy Quran*, was published, many readers asked me: "You compared the Abrahamic traditions; what if you compared the Bible with the Shaiva tradition of our own land?" That question is the seed of this book. But before we begin this journey, one thing must be said plainly. This book does not say "Shiva is Adam." In the Shaiva tradition Lord Shiva is not the first man; he is the Supreme, the Lord (*pati*), the source of all. To equate the two would be to disrespect the faith of Shaiva devotees, and it would also be intellectually dishonest.

What, then, does this book do? When the two traditions speak about the beginning of human life, the nature of humanity, its fall or forgetting, and its liberation, they use strikingly similar symbols: the holy mountain, the flowing river, the union of man and woman, the serpent, poison, light, the word. Placing these parallels side by side reveals two things: where both traditions point in the same direction, and where they clearly part ways.

I am a Christian, trained in theology. So at the end of this comparison I will state my faith openly: I believe that what the first Adam lost, Jesus Christ, "the last Adam," has restored. But to say this I do not need to belittle anyone's God. Respecting the beauty of the Shaiva Tirumurai, the depth of Tirumular and the

subtlety of the Kashmiri sages, I have tried to show what they actually say, in their own words.

In the streets of Thoothukudi the temple bell and the church bell ring together on the same breeze. This book rises from that soil of harmony. May Shaiva readers feel that their tradition has been spoken of with respect; may Christian readers see the depth of their faith in a new light; and may everyone think and wonder on this journey that stretches from Kailash to Calvary. That is my prayer.

With love,

Neelam P.J. Pradeep Jesudas, B.Th

Author

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CHAPTER 1

The Search for the Beginning

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"In the beginning..." — two great ways of thinking about origins.

1.1 The First Question of Every Religion

One of the first big questions a child asks is, "Where did I come from?" Humanity has asked the same question since its earliest days. Looking at the sky, the stars and the sea, early humans wondered: "How did all this come to be? Who is behind it?" Every tradition gives its own answer, and from that

answer all its other ideas branch out: who we are, what sin or suffering is, and how we are set free.

In this chapter we place two answers side by side. One is the answer of the Shaiva tradition, especially the philosophical school known as Kashmir Shaivism and the Tamil Shaiva Siddhanta. The other is the answer of the first verse of the Bible and the first verse of John's Gospel. Both use words like "light" and "word"; we will look carefully at how much their meanings overlap and how much they differ.

1.2 Shaivism: The World as the Unfolding of Consciousness

The Shaiva tradition explains the world's appearance in many ways. The Puranas speak through stories; the philosophical texts speak through subtle reasoning. The *Pratyabhijna* (Recognition) philosophy, developed in Kashmir between the ninth and eleventh centuries by sages such as Vasugupta, Somananda, Utpaladeva, Abhinavagupta and Kshemaraja, speaks of this very deeply.

In their view Shiva is pure consciousness (*chit*), and that consciousness is utterly free. The first sutra of Kshemaraja's *Pratyabhijnahridayam* says:

> "Chitih svatantra vishvasiddhi hetuh" — Consciousness, in its freedom, is the cause of the world's existence.

In this philosophy the world is not created "out of nothing." Rather, Shiva's consciousness displays the world within itself as *abhasa* (appearance, manifestation). Their favourite image is a mirror: as a whole city is reflected in a mirror without the mirror being anything other than itself, so the world appears within Shiva's consciousness. Shiva is called *prakasha* (light), and the power of that light to know itself is called *vimarsha*. Vimarsha is Shakti. Light and its self-awareness cannot be separated.

The Tamil Shaiva Siddhanta has a somewhat different view. Meykandar's *Sivajnana Bodham* (13th century) teaches that *pati* (God), *pashu* (souls) and *pasham* (bonds) are all beginningless. God brings forth the world from a primal substance called *maya*, for the good of souls, by his power; he sustains it and withdraws it. Here too there is no "creation from nothing," but manifestation from an existing source.

The Ananda Tandava, the dance of bliss at Chidambaram, is the most beautiful symbol of this idea. In one of Nataraja's hands is the drum (the sound of creation), in another fire (dissolution); one hand offers protection; the planted foot subdues Muyalakan (ignorance), and the raised foot shows grace. Creation, preservation, destruction, concealment and grace, the five divine acts, take place as one dance, one *lila*.

1.3 The Bible: From Nothing, by a Word

Now let us open the first page of the Bible:

> "In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth." (Genesis 1:1)

The whole biblical worldview is contained in this one verse. First, there is a beginning ("In the beginning"). Second, before that beginning God alone exists. Third, he "created"; the Hebrew word here is *bara*. In the Old Testament only God is ever the subject of this verb. Humans "make" things from existing material; only God "creates" something new.

Later Jewish and Christian thinkers explained this as "creation out of nothing" (*creatio ex nihilo*). The Letter to the Hebrews says it clearly: "things which are seen were not made of things which do appear" (Hebrews 11:3). The world is not a part of God or his reflection; it is a creation made by him, distinct from him, yet loved by him.

How did he create? By speaking. "And God said, Let there be light: and there was light" (Genesis 1:3). In the first chapter of Genesis the phrase "God

said" returns again and again. Creation is not a dance or a game; it is a word, a call, a command. At the end of each day comes the refrain, "God saw that it was good." The world is not illusion or dream; it is "good," and on the sixth day "very good" (Genesis 1:31).

1.4 The Seven Days of Genesis: A Story

Read the first chapter of Genesis with a poet's eyes. At the beginning, "the earth was without form, and void; and darkness was upon the face of the deep. And the Spirit of God moved upon the face of the waters" (Genesis 1:2). Like a bird fluttering over its nest, God's Spirit hovers over that dark expanse of water. There is no sound yet, no shape, no life.

Then the first word: "Let there be light." The darkness splits open. God names the light "Day" and the darkness "Night." On the second day, the "firmament" divides the waters above from the waters below. On the third day the sea draws back and dry land appears; grass, seed-bearing plants and fruit trees spring up. On the fourth day, sun, moon and stars; on the fifth, creatures of the sea and birds; on the sixth, the animals of the land, and finally the human being.

There is a beautiful order in this structure. In the first three days God makes "spaces": light and dark, sky and sea, land. In the next three days he "fills" them: lights, birds and fish, animals and humans. First the house is built, then the residents arrive. On the seventh day God "rested," and blessed and sanctified that day (Genesis 2:2–3). The climax of creation is not work but rest: the peace of relationship.

Compared with the creation stories of neighbouring ancient peoples, the uniqueness of this chapter is plain. In the Babylonian *Enuma Elish* the gods wage war; heaven and earth are made by splitting the body of a sea goddess; humans are created as servants of the gods. In Genesis there is no war, no rival.

The sun and moon are not gods, only lamps that God hung in the sky. Humans are made not as slaves but as God's image, stewards of creation.

1.5 Vak and Word: A Striking Parallel

Here is the first surprise of this comparison. In Kashmir Shaivism, Shiva's self-awareness is called *para vak*, the supreme Word. Utpaladeva's *Ishvara Pratyabhijna Karika* praises self-awareness as the essence of consciousness and as the freedom of the Lord. From that supreme Word, the tradition explains, arise through the levels called *pashyanti*, *madhyama* and *vaikhari* the letters, sounds and words, and finally the objects of the world. In other words, at the beginning of the world there is a "Word."

Now read the opening lines of John's Gospel:

> "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God. The same was in the beginning with God. All things were made by him; and without him was not any thing made that was made." (John 1:1–3)

Both traditions say, "In the beginning, the Word." But the difference is profound. In Shaivism the Word is the power of consciousness, a philosophical principle. John's "Word" (Greek *logos*) is a person: John says "he." And that Word one day entered our history: "And the Word was made flesh, and dwelt among us, ... full of grace and truth" (John 1:14).

The same likeness and difference appear with light. Shaivism calls Shiva *prakasha*, pure light. In the Bible the first word of creation is "Let there be light." John continues: "In him was life; and the life was the light of men" (John 1:4). In one, light is the nature of consciousness; in the other, light is the life that a person gives.

✦ Did you know?

The first word of the Hebrew Bible is *bereshit* ("In the beginning"). John deliberately begins his Gospel with the Greek form of the same phrase (*en arche*). In other words, John 1:1 is a "second edition" of Genesis 1:1: it retells the story of the first creation through Christ, the Word.

1.6 The Pillar of Light in the Shiva Purana: The Boundless Lord

One of the most famous origin stories of the Shaiva tradition is that of *Lingodbhava*, told in the Shiva Purana, the Linga Purana and other texts. Once Brahma and Vishnu quarrelled: "Which of us is greater?" Then between them a vast pillar of fire appeared; neither its bottom nor its top could be seen. They agreed, "Whoever finds its end is the greater." Vishnu took the form of a boar (Varaha) and dug downward; Brahma took the form of a swan and flew upward. Ages passed, and neither could find the end. Then from the middle of that pillar Lord Shiva emerged.

In Tamil Nadu the Karthigai Deepam festival at Tiruvannamalai is celebrated in connection with this story; tradition says the mountain itself is the form of the pillar of light. On the rear wall of the sanctum of many Shiva temples one can see the Lingodbhava sculpture: Shiva in the middle of the pillar, the boar below, the swan above.

The message of this story is deep: God cannot be measured by human effort, or even by the effort of the gods. He is known only if he reveals himself. Here a close echo of the Bible is heard: "No man hath seen God at any time; the only begotten Son, which is in the bosom of the Father, he hath declared him" (John 1:18). Both traditions meet in the truth that "God reveals himself." The difference is in the form of the revelation: in one, a boundless pillar of light; in the other, a human face.

It is worth remembering too that when the Israelites journeyed in the wilderness, God went before them "by night in a pillar of fire" (Exodus 13:21). The image of a pillar of fire appears in both traditions as a sign of God's presence.

1.7 Play or Love?

To the question "Why did God bring forth the world?" both traditions give beautiful answers. In Shaivism it is God's *lila*, the overflowing of his bliss. God needs nothing; his abundant joy becomes a dance. Shaiva Siddhanta adds that God, in compassion, brings forth the world so that souls may be freed from their bonds. It is a lovely thought: the world is a hospital and God is the physician.

The Bible's answer is love. "God is love" (1 John 4:8). Christianity believes that God, as Father, Son and Holy Spirit, has eternally been a relationship of love. That love overflowed and made a creation capable of relationship with him. That is why, at the climax of creation, God speaks with the human being, gives him the task of naming, and walks in the garden in the cool of the day.

So already in the first chapter two paths appear. In Shaivism the world is God's manifestation and is ultimately one with him (especially in Kashmir Shaivism). In the Bible the world is God's creation, distinct from him, yet called into relationship with him. One moves toward "oneness," the other toward "relationship." Keep this difference in mind; it will return again and again throughout this book.

1.8 John's Prologue: A Line-by-Line Reading

Scholars call the first eighteen verses of John's Gospel the "Prologue." It is built like a poem; each line climbs a step higher. First the Word is in eternity: "In the beginning was the Word." Then it acts in creation: "All things were made by him." Then it becomes light for humanity: "the life was the light of men." Then

it clashes with darkness: "And the light shineth in darkness; and the darkness comprehended it not" (John 1:5). Then it comes into the world, but is rejected: "He came unto his own, and his own received him not" (1:11). Finally, those who receive him gain a new identity: "But as many as received him, to them gave he power to become the sons of God, even to them that believe on his name" (1:12).

Notice this journey: eternity → creation → light → struggle with darkness → becoming human → making humans children. This is not mere philosophy; it is a story, a history. The "Word" of Kashmir Shaivism shows the levels descending from consciousness to objects; John's "Word" descends from eternity all the way to a cattle shed. Both have a "descent"; but in one it is levels of consciousness, in the other the humble journey of a person.

John chose this word for a reason. For Greek philosophers *logos* was the reason that orders the cosmos; for Jews "the word of God" was God's creating and redeeming action. John speaks to both worlds at once: "The cosmic reason you seek and the divine word you await are a person; his name is Jesus." Had John written in Tamil Nadu today, one wonders whether he might have used the term *para vak* too!

1.9 Why Does This Matter to Us?

Some may ask, "How the world began is a problem for philosophers; what does it matter to ordinary people?" But our belief about the beginning shapes our daily life. If the world is an illusion, its sufferings and injustices may seem ultimately unimportant. If the world is a creation God called "good," then caring for it and establishing justice in it is our responsibility.

It must be said that the Shaiva tradition does not simply reject the world either. Shaiva Siddhanta regards the world as real (*sat*); Kashmir Shaivism too celebrates the world as Shiva's real manifestation and does not dismiss it as "mere illusion." To this extent both traditions honour life in the world.

As a social worker I see it this way: the seashore of Thoothukudi, its salt pans, its palm trees, and the fishermen who toil at sea are all part of God's creation. Polluting them and exploiting the poor is an insult to the Creator himself. "The earth is the LORD's, and the fulness thereof" (Psalm 24:1).

1.10 The Five Acts and the One God at Work

According to the Shaiva tradition God performs five acts: creation (*srishti*), preservation (*sthiti*), destruction or withdrawal (*samhara*), concealment (*tirobhava*) and grace (*anugraha*). All are acts of the one Shiva. It is notable that "concealment" and "grace" are counted as God's acts: God himself conceals himself according to the ripeness of souls, and then, at the right time, reveals himself by grace. Even "destruction" is not annihilation; it is rest for weary souls, a preparation for a new beginning.

In the Bible too one God does everything. He creates (Genesis 1), sustains ("upholding all things by the word of his power," Hebrews 1:3), judges (Noah's flood), hides himself ("Verily thou art a God that hidest thyself," Isaiah 45:15), and gives grace. This parallel is striking. Both traditions see God not as a "distant clockmaker" but as one continually at work.

But the Bible adds an extra element: history is not a circle but a line. In the Shaiva and Hindu traditions creation and dissolution revolve age after age (the *kalpas*). In the Bible history moves from a beginning (Genesis) toward a goal (Revelation), with a central point between: the cross and resurrection of Christ. "Behold, I make all things new" (Revelation 21:5).

For Reflection

1. How might the difference between the world as God's "manifestation" and as God's "creation" affect your daily life?
2. The Lingodbhava story and John 1:18 both say that humans cannot measure God. Then how can we know God?
3. How does the verse "God saw that it was good" change your view of the environment?

Comparison

	Shaiva tradition	The Bible
How the world?	Manifestation of consciousness (abhasa); emergence from maya	Creation from nothing (Gen 1:1)
In the beginning	Para vak: the power of consciousness	The Word: a person, Christ (John 1:1)
Light	Shiva = prakasha, Shakti = vimarsha	"Let there be light" (Gen 1:3)
Why create?	Lila, bliss, compassion for souls	Love, relationship (1 John 4:8)
World and God	Ultimately one (Kashmir)	Distinct, yet in relationship

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CHAPTER 2

Adiyogi and the First Man



The first teacher and the first man — two "firsts."

2.1 Two "Firsts"

In Tamil the word *adi* ("first, primal") has a special majesty. Thiruvalluvar opens his great work: "As A is the first of all letters, so the Primal God is first of the world." In the Shaiva tradition Lord Shiva bears names such as *Adinatha* and *Adisivan*. In recent times the name *Adiyogi*, "the first yogi," has become widely known around the world. In the Bible, Adam is "the first man." The Hebrew word *adam* itself means "human being," and it is linked to *adamah*, "ground" or "soil."

Placing the two "firsts" side by side, the first feeling is wonder. But a caution is needed at once. For Shaivas, Adiyogi is not a man; he is God himself, who taught humanity yoga and wisdom. Adam is the first human, created by God. So what we compare is not their "status" but the "role" each plays in the story of humanity.

2.2 The First Teacher: Dakshinamurthy

The most beautiful form of the first teacher in the Shaiva tradition is Dakshinamurthy: a young teacher seated beneath a banyan tree, facing south, and before him four aged sages, Sanaka and his brothers. The teacher says nothing; tradition says the doubts of the disciples were dispelled in his silence. The *Dakshinamurthy Stotram*, attributed to Adi Shankara, praises this silent guru. This form can still be seen on the southern wall of the Shiva temples of Tamil Nadu.

In the yoga traditions Shiva is honoured as the original teacher of yoga; many hatha yoga texts frame their teachings as words spoken by Shiva to Parvati. In this sense Adiyogi is "the first teacher who shows humanity the way to God." The path he teaches is that the human being should master body, breath and mind, turn inward, and know his true nature.

2.3 Other Stories of the First Man

The story of the first man does not belong only to the Bible. In the Hindu tradition too there are stories of the forefather of humanity. Manu is regarded as the father of humankind; tradition says words such as *manushya* and *manava* come from his name. The flood story of Manu in the Shatapatha Brahmana, in which a fish warns him and saves him in a boat, reminds many of Noah's ark. The *Purusha Sukta* of the Rig Veda sings that the world arose from the sacrifice of a cosmic man (*purusha*).

Some may ask why this book compares Adiyogi with Adam and not with Manu. The reason is simple: this book focuses on the "Shaiva tradition," and the symbol of "Adiyogi" is widely known among the younger generation today. But one thing should be made clear: many scholars regard the presence in many traditions of stories of a "first man," a "great flood," and a "lost golden age" as showing a memory, a longing, common to humanity. Christians see this as the "memory of eternity" God placed in the heart of every people (Ecclesiastes 3:11: "he hath set the world in their heart").

2.4 The First Man: Dust and Breath

Adam's story begins in a completely different direction. He is nobody's teacher; he is the first student. Genesis describes his origin like this:

> "And the LORD God formed man of the dust of the ground, and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life; and man became a living soul." (Genesis 2:7)

This verse shows the double nature of humanity. He is "dust": bound to the earth, weak, mortal. Yet within him is God's "breath": he is not mere dust; God's life is in him. As a potter bends over clay to shape it, as a mother bends close to her baby's face and breathes, God comes very near to the human being. No other creature is described with this intimacy.

Surprisingly, the yoga tradition also places breath (*prana*) at the centre. Pranayama controls the breath to awaken the energy within. In the Bible, breath is not a practice a person performs; it is a gift God gives. The Hebrew word *ruach* means breath, wind and spirit all at once. Human life itself is the breath of God.

2.5 Adam's First Day in Eden

Imagine Adam's first day. When he opened his eyes, the first thing he saw was the face of the one who made him. All around, a newly sprung garden, nameless trees, nameless birds. God gives him his first work: "And the LORD God took the man, and put him into the garden of Eden to dress it and to keep it" (Genesis 2:15). Humanity's first calling is work; but not cursed toil, rather the joyful work of caring for creation together with God. The dignity of labour is not a punishment that came after sin; it is humanity's honour from the very beginning of creation.

The second task is even more beautiful. "And out of the ground the LORD God formed every beast of the field, and every fowl of the air; and brought them unto Adam to see what he would call them" (Genesis 2:19). Like a teacher eagerly awaiting a student's answer, God "waits to see what he would call them." The language, knowledge and creativity given to humans are all visible in this scene. To name something is to understand it and to take responsibility for it.

Third, a limit: "But of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, thou shalt not eat of it" (Genesis 2:17). The whole garden is his; only one tree is not. That limit is not a prison; it is a test of love. Love cannot be forced; only where there is freedom to choose is love real. Adam is not a robot; he is a son.

✦ An interesting fact

In many places in the Bible the Hebrew word *adam* (אָדָם) is not the name of an individual but the general term "human being," "humankind." It is linked by sound to *adamah* (ground); in English we might say "earthling." In Genesis 5:2 God named the man and the woman together "Adam."

2.6 The Image of God: Humanity's Glory

The highest word the Bible speaks about Adam is this:

> "So God created man in his own image, in the image of God created he him; male and female created he them." (Genesis 1:27)

What is an "image"? Ancient kings set up statues of themselves in the territories they ruled; the statue announced, "This land belongs to this king." In the same way the human being is God's living "image" on earth, called to reflect his love and justice in creation. That is why every person, regardless of caste, religion, colour or gender, has immeasurable worth. This single verse is the foundation of all human equality.

Shaivism also gives humanity high dignity, but in a different way. Tirumular says, "The heart is the great temple; this body of flesh is the shrine." The human body is a temple, the heart its sanctum. Kashmir Shaivism goes a step further, saying that the consciousness in the depths of a person is Shiva's own consciousness. The Bible says "the human is the image of God"; Kashmir Shaivism says "the human, in his depths, is God." The difference between image and essence is enormous. The sun's reflection in a mirror shines like the sun, but it is not the sun. In the Bible, the human being is that shining mirror.

2.7 The Sixty-Four Sacred Plays of Shiva: God Coming Down to People

In the Shaiva tradition God teaches humanity not only through yoga texts. The *Thiruvilaiyadal Puranam*, composed by Paranjothi Munivar, sings of sixty-four sacred plays that Lord Shiva performed at Madurai. In them God comes down into the lives of ordinary people: for a poor old woman, Vandhi, he comes as a hired labourer and carries earth to dam the bank of the river Vaigai; because he played instead of working, he is struck with the king's cane; and that

blow falls on every living being in the world. This story, linked with Manikkavasagar, is deeply engraved in Tamil hearts.

A Christian reader reading this story will be startled. A God who comes as a labourer for the poor, is beaten, and bears that blow for all! Paul's words come to mind: "Who, being in the form of God... took upon him the form of a servant, and was made in the likeness of men" (Philippians 2:6–7), along with Isaiah's words, "with his stripes we are healed."

But here too an honest difference must be noted. The sacred plays are God's *lila*, temporary forms; God "appears" like a man and then vanishes. In Christian faith God "became" man: he grew in the womb, was born, hungered, wept, died, and even after rising remains in a human body. This is the shock of "the Word was made flesh."

2.8 Teacher and Student: Different Roles

Now we can compare the roles of the two "firsts." Adiyogi teaches humanity the way; humans must walk that way and rise. Adam is the one who turned aside from the way. His story is not "how humans climb up to God" but "how God comes seeking humans who have left him."

Yet the biblical story has a remarkable twist. A "teacher" appears there too, and he is God himself, come as a man. Jesus Christ called himself "Teacher"; he sat on a mountain and taught. But he did not merely point out a way; he said, "I am the way, the truth, and the life" (John 14:6). The apostle Paul calls him "the last Adam" (1 Corinthians 15:45). So in the Bible the "first teacher" and the "first man" finally meet in one person: God become man. We will return to this truth in the last chapter of this book.

2.9 Image and Idol: A Careful Note

The biblical idea of the image of God is linked with an important commandment: "Thou shalt not make unto thee any graven image, or any likeness of any thing" (Exodus 20:4). Why? One reason is that God has already placed his image in the world: the human being. If you want to see God's image, look at your neighbour's face; love him. "He that loveth not his brother whom he hath seen, how can he love God whom he hath not seen?" (1 John 4:20).

In the Shaiva tradition image worship is central: the linga, Nataraja, the divine couple. But here too there is subtlety. Shaivas explain the linga as a form that is not a form (*aruvuruvam*); Siddhanta says God is form, form-formless and formless. Just as Tirumular called the human body a temple, Shaiva devotees honoured the principle of "serving the devotees of Shiva as Shiva himself." Many Nayanmars in the Periya Puranam made feeding devotees their very worship.

Here the two traditions meet in a beautiful place: feeding the hungry is doing it to God. Jesus said, "Inasmuch as ye have done it unto one of the least of these my brethren, ye have done it unto me" (Matthew 25:40).

2.10 The Line of Adam: Good News Hidden in Names

Genesis chapter 5 is the genealogy from Adam to Noah. Most readers pass over it quickly: long lifespans, difficult names. But a thread of hope runs even through that list. After each name comes a sad refrain: "...and he died." The warning given to Adam, "thou shalt surely die," is fulfilled in every generation.

One name breaks that refrain of death: Enoch. "And Enoch walked with God: and he was not; for God took him" (Genesis 5:24). For a man who walked with God, death was not the last word. Enoch tasted again the relationship of walking with God that was lost in the garden.

At the end of the list Lamech names his son "Noah" (rest): "This same shall comfort us concerning our work and toil of our hands, because of the ground

which the LORD hath cursed" (Genesis 5:29). In the middle of the curse, a longing for a deliverer. This longing is in the heart of every child of Adam, and in ours. Luke's Gospel traces Jesus' genealogy backward through these names and ends with "Adam, which was the son of God" (Luke 3:38). In this way Luke shows that Jesus belongs not only to the Jews but to the whole family of Adam.

2.11 A Beginning Without Caste

Adam's story has a social dimension, and it is very important in our Tamil context. If all humans come from one Adam, no one is high or low by birth. Paul proclaimed in Athens that God "hath made of one blood all nations of men" (Acts 17:26). Writing on behalf of a trust that bears Dr Ambedkar's name, I hear this verse ring like a political charter.

In the Shaiva tradition too there are voices that sound the same note. The line "One community, one God" (*Onre kulam oruvane thevan*) is widely quoted as belonging to the Tirumantiram. Among the sixty-three Nayanmars of the Periya Puranam are people of many castes; a devotee from an oppressed community such as Nandanar is honoured. Appar thundered against power: "We are subjects to no one."

But it is a painful truth that in practice caste is still alive in both communities. If our beliefs about the "beginning" are true, they must change our streets, our graveyards and our marriages.

For Reflection

1. What "naming" responsibility has God given you, that is, the work, relationships and community entrusted to you?
2. What do the story of Shiva carrying earth for Vandhi and the story of Christ taking the form of a servant tell you about God?
3. How should the belief that "all are children of one Adam" change the view of caste in your town?

Comparison

	Shaiva tradition	The Bible
Who?	Adiyogi: God who teaches humanity	Adam: a human created by God
Role	First guru, shows the way	First student, strays from the way
Breath	Pranayama: a practice humans perform	Breath of life: God's gift (Gen 2:7)
Human worth	Body as temple; Shiva-consciousness within	Image of God (Gen 1:27)
Fulfilment	Disciple attains the guru's state	Christ the last Adam (1 Cor 15:45)

CHAPTER 3

Kailash and Eden

✦



The snow mountain and the garden — dwelling places of God.

3.1 Why Do Humans Seek Mountains?

Almost every tradition in the world has sacred mountains. A mountain rises from the earth toward the sky, so people saw it as the meeting place of God and humanity. In Tamil Nadu alone there are so many hill temples: Tiruvannamalai, Palani, Thiruparankundram! Sangam literature celebrates Murugan as the one who "dances on every hill." Mountains also have a great place in the Bible: Ararat, Moriah, Sinai, Zion, the Mount of Transfiguration, the Mount of Olives, Calvary.

David sang: “Who shall ascend into the hill of the LORD? or who shall stand in his holy place? He that hath clean hands, and a pure heart…” (Psalm 24:3–4). Both traditions knew that climbing a mountain is not only a journey of the body but a journey of the heart.

3.2 From Sinai to Zion: The Mountains of the Bible

The Bible’s story could almost be told through its mountains. After the great flood, Noah’s ark rested “upon the mountains of Ararat” (Genesis 8:4): a new beginning on a mountain. Abraham climbed Mount Moriah to sacrifice his son Isaac; there God provided a ram as a substitute. Abraham named that place “Jehovah-jireh,” “the LORD will provide” (Genesis 22:14). Later, the Bible says, the Jerusalem temple was built “in mount Moriah” (2 Chronicles 3:1).

Moses met God on Mount Sinai amid fire and thunder and received the Ten Commandments. The people stood in fear at the foot of the mountain; they were not even allowed to touch it. The prophet Elijah confronted the prophets of Baal on Mount Carmel; later, on Mount Horeb, he met God not in the wind, the earthquake or the fire, but in “a still small voice” (1 Kings 19:12).

In the New Testament Jesus sat on a mountain and preached the Beatitudes. On the mount of transfiguration his face shone like the sun; Moses and Elijah talked with him. On the Mount of Olives he wept, prayed and was arrested. Finally, Calvary. All the mountains point to this one hill: on Moriah a ram died in Isaac’s place; at Calvary “the Lamb of God” died in the place of all humanity.

The Letter to the Hebrews expresses this change beautifully: you have not come to Sinai, the mountain that might not be touched and that burned with fire; “But ye are come unto mount Sion, and unto the city of the living God, the heavenly Jerusalem” (Hebrews 12:18–22). From the mountain of fear to the mountain of love.

3.3 Kailash: Shiva's Abode

Mount Kailash stands in the Himalayan range, in present-day Tibet, at a height of about 6,600 metres. It is sacred to four traditions: Hindus, Buddhists, Jains and followers of Bon. A special feature is that no climber has ever stood on its summit; it is said that out of respect for its sanctity, permission to climb is not granted. Pilgrims walk around it instead.

In the Shaiva tradition Kailash is where Lord Shiva and Parvati dwell. The cry "O Lord of the Kailash mountain!" appears often in the Thevaram hymns. The Periya Puranam tells that Thirunavukkarasar (Appar) in his old age set out on foot to see Kailash, and that the Lord made him plunge into a tank and rise at Thiruvaiyaru, where he was granted the vision of Kailash itself. The message of the story is beautiful: God's abode is not only far away; God can reveal it right where his devotee is.

Some of Asia's great rivers rise in the Kailash region: the Indus, the Sutlej, the Brahmaputra (in Tibet the Yarlung Tsangpo), and the Karnali, a tributary of the Ganga. Nearby Lake Manasarovar is also held sacred. That from one mountain many rivers flow to give life to millions is both a geographical fact and a spiritual symbol.

3.4 The Story of Ravana Lifting Kailash

One of the most dramatic stories about Kailash is that of Ravana. Ravana, king of Lanka, proud of his might, once tried to lift and shake Mount Kailash itself. The mountain trembled; Uma was afraid. Then Lord Shiva, smiling, pressed the mountain lightly with his toe. Ravana's arms were crushed beneath the mountain. Crying out in pain, Ravana made his own sinews the strings of a vina and sang Sama hymns in praise of the Lord. Moved by his song, Shiva released him and blessed him; so the tradition says.

This story recurs again and again in the Thevaram; scholars point out that Thirugnanasambandar habitually mentions Ravana crushed beneath Kailash in

the eighth verse of his hymns. The Kailasanatha cave temple at Ellora has a famous sculpture of this scene.

The message is clear: the holy mountain cannot be seized by force; it can be approached only with humility and praise. It fits beautifully with the biblical story of the tower of Babel. People said, "Go to, let us build us a city and a tower, whose top may reach unto heaven; and let us make us a name" (Genesis 11:4). Their languages were confused as they tried in pride to reach heaven. "God resisteth the proud, but giveth grace unto the humble" (James 4:6).

3.5 Eden: The Garden of God

The Bible describes humanity's first home as a garden: "And the LORD God planted a garden eastward in Eden; and there he put the man whom he had formed" (Genesis 2:8). In the middle of that garden stood the tree of life and the tree of the knowledge of good and evil.

Many do not know that the Bible also presents Eden as a mountain. The prophet Ezekiel speaks of Eden as "the garden of God" and, in the same passage, of "the holy mountain of God" (Ezekiel 28:13–14). So Eden too is a holy mountain-garden, where God dwells and where humans meet him. Adam "heard the voice of the LORD God walking in the garden in the cool of the day" (Genesis 3:8). God walks in the garden and keeps company with humans like a friend.

✦ Did you know?

Because Kailash has a roughly four-faced, pyramid-like shape, many traditions regard it as the axis of the world, the earthly form of Mount Meru. In the Bible, in the vision of the new temple that Ezekiel saw, a river flows out, growing deeper as it goes, and makes even the Dead Sea fresh (Ezekiel 47). How powerful the image of a river of life flowing from a holy mountain is in both traditions!

3.6 The Ganga and the Four Rivers

The loveliest parallel in this comparison lies in the rivers. According to Hindu tradition, when the Ganga descended from heaven to earth, the earth could not bear the force of her fall; so, at the plea of Bhagiratha, Lord Shiva caught her in his matted hair and released her gently to the earth. That is why he is called *Gangadhara*, bearer of the Ganga. The Ganga is honoured as the holy river that washes away sins and grants release to the ancestors.

In Eden too a river flows: "And a river went out of Eden to water the garden; and from thence it was parted, and became into four heads" (Genesis 2:10). Their names are given as Pison, Gihon, Hiddekel (the Tigris) and Euphrates. As many rivers flow from the Kailash region, so from Eden four rivers go out toward the four quarters of the world.

In the last pages of the Bible this river appears again: "a pure river of water of life, clear as crystal, proceeding out of the throne of God and of the Lamb," with the tree of life on either side (Revelation 22:1–2). Jesus said, "If any man thirst, let him come unto me, and drink... out of his belly shall flow rivers of living water" (John 7:37–38). For a reader who honours the belief that the Ganga washes away sin, this image of "living water" will speak very closely.

3.7 A Garden of Trees: The Tree of Life and the Banyan

In the middle of Eden stand two trees: the tree of life and the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. Humanity's destiny was decided before a tree. In the Hindu tradition too, sacred trees have a great place. The Bhagavad Gita (chapter 15) speaks of the *ashvattha* tree with roots above and branches below as an image of worldly existence. Dakshinamurthy sits beneath a banyan tree. Every Shiva temple has a *sthala vriksha*, a sacred temple tree: the tillai tree at Chidambaram, the kadamba tree at Madurai, and so on.

The Bible's tree story reaches its climax in three places. In Eden the fruit of a tree brought humanity down. At Calvary Christ hung on a tree; Peter

deliberately calls the cross a "tree" (Acts 5:30; 1 Peter 2:24). In the new Jerusalem the tree of life appears again, "and the leaves of the tree were for the healing of the nations" (Revelation 22:2). Old church hymns sang that what was lost through a tree was regained through a tree.

In our villages the shade of the banyan tree is where the panchayat meets, where children play and where travellers rest. The image of a community gathering in the shade of a tree is common to both traditions.

3.8 The Lost Garden and the Opened Gate

But the two stories move toward different endings. Kailash is still Shiva's abode; the devotee goes there on pilgrimage and longs to reach Sivalokam at the end of life. Eden is the place humanity lost. After sin, cherubim and "a flaming sword which turned every way" were set "to keep the way of the tree of life" (Genesis 3:24). No human effort can open that gate.

The whole story of the Bible is about that gate being opened again. To a thief hanging on a cross, Jesus said, "To day shalt thou be with me in paradise" (Luke 23:43). "Paradise" is an old word for "garden." For humanity, which cannot climb the mountain to reach God, God himself came down to a mountain, Calvary, and opened the gate of the lost garden. That is why this book is called *From Kailash to Calvary*.

3.9 Bathing in the Ganga and Baptism in the Jordan

Millions of Hindus regard bathing in the Ganga as a sacred duty of life. The crowds at the Kumbh Mela are considered the largest human gathering on earth. In Tamil Nadu too, the Pushkaram of the Thamirabarani, the Mahamaham tank of Kumbakonam and the holy waters of Rameswaram express the same belief. The longing for water to cleanse not only the body but the heart runs deep in humanity.

In the Bible too one river is central: the Jordan. The Israelites crossed the Jordan to enter the promised land. Elisha told Naaman, the Syrian commander, to dip seven times in the Jordan to be healed of leprosy; Naaman grew angry ("Are not the rivers of my own land better?"), but at last he humbly dipped, "and his flesh came again like unto the flesh of a little child, and he was clean" (2 Kings 5:14). In that same Jordan John the Baptist gave the people a baptism of repentance; Jesus too was baptised there.

But the New Testament makes an important distinction: the water of baptism does not wash away sin by itself; it is a sign of dying and rising with Christ (Romans 6:4). What washes away sin is "the blood of Jesus Christ his Son" (1 John 1:7). Immersion in water is the outward confession of a change that has happened within. To the longing of the Ganga's banks for cleansing, Christianity answers: "If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins, and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness" (1 John 1:9).

3.10 Sivalokam and Heaven: The Final Home

The final longing of Shaiva devotees is "Sivalokam," or "reaching Shiva's feet." In the Periya Puranam the stories of many Nayanmars end with "he reached Sivalokam" or "he attained the shade of the Lord's holy feet." Appar's famous hymn describes that shade like this: the shade of the Lord's feet is like the music of a flawless vina, the evening moon, the blowing southern breeze, early spring, and a lotus pond humming with bees. In a world full of suffering, God's shade is rest.

The Bible too sings of God's "shadow": "He that dwelleth in the secret place of the most High shall abide under the shadow of the Almighty" (Psalm 91:1). But the Bible's final hope is not only that humans "go" to a distant world; it is that God "comes" to humans. In the final vision of Revelation the new Jerusalem comes down out of heaven, and a voice proclaims: "Behold, the tabernacle of God is with men, and he will dwell with them... And God shall

wipe away all tears from their eyes; and there shall be no more death, neither sorrow, nor crying, neither shall there be any more pain" (Revelation 21:3–4).

Kailash is a mountain humans must climb; the new Jerusalem is a city God brings down. Eden is a garden; the new Jerusalem is a city that contains the garden: the river of life in the middle, the tree of life on either bank. The Bible begins in a garden and ends in a garden-city. Human culture, labour and the arts are all redeemed and brought into that city: "the kings of the earth do bring their glory and honour into it" (21:24).

For Reflection

1. What do the story of Ravana and the tower of Babel teach about pride? Has there been a moment in your life when you tried to "lift the mountain"?
2. Thirunavukkarasar was granted the vision of Kailash right at Thiruvaiyaru. Have you ever met God in an unexpected place?
3. What does the idea "what was lost through a tree was regained through a tree" add to your view of the cross?

Comparison

	Shaiva tradition	The Bible
Holy place	Mount Kailash	Garden of Eden / mountain of God (Ezek 28)
River	Ganga, borne in Shiva's hair	One river, four heads (Gen 2:10)
God's presence	Where Shiva and Uma dwell	God walking in the garden (Gen 3:8)
Human condition	Pilgrimage, longing for Sivalokam	Lost garden, closed gate (Gen 3:24)
Fulfilment	Sivalokam	River of life, paradise (Rev 22; Luke 23:43)

✦ ✦ ✦

CHAPTER 4

Ardhanarishvara and "One Flesh"

✦



One body shared in halves; two becoming one flesh — two pictures of the unity of man and woman.

4.1 Half a Body, Complete Unity

The form in which Shiva and Shakti are joined half and half in a single body is called *Ardhanarishvara*, "the Lord who is half woman." The right half is male, with matted locks and trident; the left half is female, with knotted hair, earring and gentle curves. At Thiruchengode there is an ancient hill temple dedicated to Ardhanarishvara. In the Thevaram, Shiva is sung as "the one who

has the Lady as his half," "the one whose half is Uma": he who gave a part of his very body to Uma.

The meaning of this form is deep. In Shaiva philosophy Shiva is consciousness and Shakti is its dynamic energy. They are not two; they are two sides of one reality. The idea that "without Shakti there is no Shiva" is widely spoken of in the Shaiva and Shakta traditions. The first verse of the *Saundarya Lahari*, attributed to Adi Shankara, sings that Shiva can act only when united with Shakti; otherwise he cannot even stir. Male and female, stillness and movement, knowledge and energy complete each other.

4.2 The Story of the Sage Bhringi: How the Half-Body Came to Be

There is a story widely told in Tamil Nadu about how the Ardhanarishvara form came about. A sage named Bhringi was resolute in worshipping Lord Shiva alone. Even when Shiva and Uma sat side by side on Kailash, he circled only Shiva and avoided Uma. When Uma had them sit close together, Bhringi, the story says, took the form of a bee, slipped between them, and circled Shiva alone.

Grieved, Uma performed severe penance. Pleased with her devotion, Lord Shiva gave her the left half of his own body. Now, to worship Shiva one must worship Shakti too; the two can no longer be separated. This story is told in some temple legends and in connection with places such as Tiruvannamalai; the details vary from place to place.

The message of this story is clear: a devotion that exalts only the male and ignores the female is not complete devotion. God himself corrected that neglect. As a social activist, I wish this story were told more often at our temple festivals and family celebrations.

4.3 A Companion from the Rib

The second chapter of Genesis shows a tender scene. Even after Adam had named all the animals, "for Adam there was not found an help meet for him." Then God said, "It is not good that the man should be alone; I will make him an help meet for him" (Genesis 2:18). The God who called all creation "good" says "not good" for the first time about human loneliness.

God caused a deep sleep to fall on Adam, took one of his ribs, and made the woman. When Adam saw her, he sang the first poem in human history:

> "This is now bone of my bones, and flesh of my flesh: she shall be called Woman, because she was taken out of Man." (Genesis 2:23)

In Hebrew there is a wordplay between *ish* (man) and *ishah* (woman), which English echoes in "man" and "woman."

4.4 "They Shall Be One Flesh"

The next verse is the founding charter of marriage:

> "Therefore shall a man leave his father and his mother, and shall cleave unto his wife: and they shall be one flesh." (Genesis 2:24)

Here a striking parallel with the Ardhanarishvara form appears. In one, a single body is shared between two; in the other, two who came from one body unite again as "one flesh." Both traditions say that man and woman are not strangers to each other, and that neither is complete without the other.

But the difference is also clear. Ardhanarishvara is a symbol of God's inner nature: masculine and feminine, consciousness and energy, are united in God himself. The story of Adam and Eve is about the relationship between two distinct human persons. They become one, yet remain separate persons; neither

swallows the other. Love is not two dissolving into one; it is two remaining two and giving themselves to each other. This is the heart of the biblical idea of "relationship."

4.5 The First Wedding in Eden: Looking at the Story Again

Read the scene of Genesis 2 slowly. God brings the animals to Adam. Lion, elephant, deer, peacock: Adam names each one. Each pair goes off together; Adam alone stands by himself. That parade is a lesson: Adam himself must realise that a fitting companion for a human is not found among the animals. He must feel the pain of loneliness.

Then God puts him into a deep sleep. A man cannot "make" his partner; she is God's gift, a miracle that happens while he sleeps. When he woke, God himself, like the father of a bride, "brought her unto the man" (Genesis 2:22). The moment at our weddings when a father takes his daughter's hand and gives her to the groom is an echo of this first wedding.

Adam's cry of joy, "This is now bone of my bones!", begins in Hebrew with "This time!" (*zot ha-pa'am*): after seeing so many animals, Adam exclaims, "At last, this is it!" The final line of the scene touches the heart: "And they were both naked, the man and his wife, and were not ashamed" (Genesis 2:25). Nothing to hide, no fear, no shame. That is the purity of relationship before sin.

✦ Did you know?

Thirugnanasambandar's very first hymn begins "*Todudaiya seviyan*": the one who wears a woman's earring in one ear, that is, Ardhanarishvara. The Periya Puranam says he sang it as a three-year-old child after drinking the milk of wisdom fed to him by Uma. Isn't it remarkable that the first line of the Thevaram begins with the symbol of the unity of man and woman!

4.6 An Old Explanation of the Rib

There are many explanations of why Eve was taken from the rib. A line written by the eighteenth-century English Bible commentator Matthew Henry is world-famous: the woman was not taken out of man's head, to rule over him; nor out of his feet, to be trampled on by him; but out of his side, to be equal with him; under his arm, to be protected; and near his heart, to be loved.

The phrase "help meet" also deserves attention. In Hebrew it is *ezer kenegdo*, "a help standing opposite him, corresponding to him." The word *ezer* (help) is used in many places in the Bible of God himself: "My help cometh from the LORD, which made heaven and earth" (Psalm 121:2). So "helper" does not mean inferior; it means one who gives strength, one who stands alongside.

Compared with the Ardhanarishvara form, both traditions tell the same truth from different angles: the woman is the man's "half," part of his body, his equal. Without her he is incomplete.

4.7 Equality of Man and Woman: A Challenge to Both Traditions

Although both symbols speak of high equality, we must honestly admit that the communities following both traditions have not always treated women as equals. Caste and patriarchy have entered temples and churches alike. As a social activist I have seen this first-hand.

That is why it is important to return to these root symbols. Can one who worships the Lord whose half is Uma treat the women of his household with contempt? Can one who reads "male and female created he them" in God's image think less of a woman? Paul writes: "There is neither Jew nor Greek, there is neither bond nor free, there is neither male nor female: for ye are all one in Christ Jesus" (Galatians 3:28).

4.8 The Great Mystery: Christ and the Church

In the New Testament, Genesis 2:24 gains a new depth. Paul quotes the verse and then says, "This is a great mystery: but I speak concerning Christ and the church" (Ephesians 5:31–32). That is, the union of husband and wife is the shadow of a greater truth: God desires to be joined with humanity in a covenant of love.

The Bible begins with a wedding (Eden) and ends with a wedding ("the marriage of the Lamb," Revelation 19:7). Shaivism sees the Shiva–Shakti union as God's inner nature; the Bible sees the God–human relationship as the love of bridegroom and bride. In one, unity is within God; in the other, love flows from God toward humanity. It is a remarkable bridge that the Thevaram and Thiruvasagam contain the "lover and beloved" mood (*nayaka–nayaki bhava*), in which devotees sang of God as the bridegroom and themselves as the bride.

4.9 Lessons for Family Life

What do these two symbols say to Tamil families today? First, respect. In the body of the Lord whose half is Uma, the left half is in no way less than the right. Eve was taken from Adam's side and is his equal. The view that sees a wife merely as a slave or a cook is contrary to the root symbols of both traditions.

Second, unity. "One flesh" refers not only to physical union but to sharing in every dimension of life: money, dreams, sorrows, decisions. Jesus said, "What therefore God hath joined together, let not man put asunder" (Matthew 19:6).

Third, sacrifice. Paul says to husbands: "Husbands, love your wives, even as Christ also loved the church, and gave himself for it" (Ephesians 5:25). A husband's "headship" is not domination; it is sacrificial love like the cross. Shiva gave half of his body to Uma; Christ gave his whole life for his bride. Both are pictures of "giving." It is giving love that builds a family.

4.10 From Thiruchengode to Cana

The most famous shrine of Ardhanarishvara in Tamil Nadu is Thiruchengode in Namakkal district. On top of that hill, rising red as its soil, the Lord is enthroned as the one whose half is Uma. Thirugnanasambandar sang of this place as "Kodimadach Chengunrur." Many married couples come here to worship and pray before the symbol of the unity of man and woman that their household may endure.

It is remarkable that in the Gospel Jesus' first miracle also took place at a wedding. A marriage feast in the town of Cana in Galilee. In the middle of the feast the wine ran out: a great shame for the family. Jesus' mother Mary noticed it and said to the servants, "Whatsoever he saith unto you, do it." Jesus told them to fill six stone jars with water; that water became the best wine (John 2:1–11).

This miracle has many meanings. First, God does not despise human joy; he blesses the celebration of marriage. Second, when lack comes (when love runs out, when patience dries up), if we bring it to him, he turns ordinary water into the best wine. Third, it is a "sign": the prophets said the age of the Messiah would be a great wedding feast (Isaiah 25:6). From the first wedding in Eden, through the wedding at Cana, to the marriage of the Lamb, the Bible is one long love story.

For Reflection

1. In your family, are women respected as an equal "half of the body"? What change is needed?
2. How does the fact that the word "helper" (*ezer*) is also used of God change your view of a woman's worth?
3. "Oneness" (two dissolving into one) and "relationship" (becoming one while remaining two): which is healthier for marriage?

Comparison

	Shaiva tradition	The Bible
Symbol	Ardhanarishvara: Shiva and Shakti in one body	Adam and Eve: one flesh (Gen 2:24)
About what?	God's inner nature	The relationship of two human persons
Kind of unity	Inseparable oneness	Becoming one while remaining two
Deeper meaning	Consciousness and energy are one	Christ and the church (Eph 5:32)
Language of devotion	Nayaka–nayaki bhava	Bridegroom and bride (Rev 19:7)



CHAPTER 5

The Serpent: Ornament or Enemy?

✦



The serpent subdued at the throat and the serpent that spoke in the garden.

5.1 Humanity's Ancient Fear

No creature both fascinates and frightens humans like the snake. It sheds its skin and is renewed, so it became a symbol of rebirth and long life. Its venom takes life, so it became a symbol of death and danger. In our villages people pour milk on anthills and celebrate Naga Chaturthi, yet reach for a stick when they see a snake; this shows the same double feeling. The serpent coiled

around a staff, used today all over the world as the emblem of medicine, continues the same story.

5.2 Vasuki on Shiva's Neck

In Shiva's images the serpent is always present: as a garland around his neck, as bracelets on his arms, as an ornament in his hair. Traditionally the one around his neck is Vasuki, king of serpents. The Puranas say that this same Vasuki served as the rope wound around Mount Mandara when the ocean of milk was churned; we will see that story in detail in Chapter 7.

What does this symbol mean? The power that frightens humans and takes their lives is subdued before God and becomes an ornament. Death and danger are under God's control. In the yoga tradition the serpent gains another meaning: the *kundalini* energy that sleeps coiled at the base of the spine is pictured as a serpent. When it awakens and rises to the crown of the head, the yogi becomes one with Shiva; so that tradition believes. Thus in the Shaiva and yoga traditions the serpent is mostly a positive, or subdued, power.

5.3 The World of the Nagas: Adishesha and Patanjali

In the Hindu tradition the serpent is not linked with Shiva alone. Vishnu reclines on the thousand-headed Adishesha in the ocean of milk; Ranganatha of Srirangam is this form. Tradition also says Adishesha bears the earth on his head. There is a tradition that the sage Patanjali, author of the Yoga Sutras, was an incarnation of Adishesha, which is why he is shown in sculpture with a serpent's body. In the story linked with Chidambaram, Patanjali and Vyaghrapada are said to have seen Nataraja's dance.

In the villages of Tamil Nadu, the worship of Nagamman, anthill worship and remedies for "naga dosha" are widespread. The serpent is also regarded as a guardian of fertility, of the earth and of water. So in the Indian setting the

serpent is mostly worthy of reverence, worthy of fear, but not fundamentally a symbol of evil.

This gives an important caution to a Christian who speaks about the biblical serpent. When one says "serpent," the minds of Hindu friends picture Shiva's ornament and Ranganatha's couch. If a Christian says in general "serpent = Satan," it may seem insulting to them. The Bible refers to that one particular "old serpent" who spoke in Eden, that is, Satan, not to every serpent symbol. In conversation this nuance matters greatly.

5.4 The Serpent of Eden

The first appearance of the serpent in the Bible is completely different. "Now the serpent was more subtil than any beast of the field which the LORD God had made" (Genesis 3:1). It comes to the woman with a question: "Yea, hath God said, Ye shall not eat of every tree of the garden?" God had said no such thing; he had spoken of only one tree. But the serpent makes her doubt God's goodness.

Then comes its main promise: "Ye shall not surely die... ye shall be as gods, knowing good and evil" (Genesis 3:4–5). Notice something subtle here. The serpent's promise is "You will become divine." The root of the first sin is the desire to become like God, not through relationship, but by one's own effort and by breaking God's command. Later the New Testament identifies that serpent as "that old serpent, called the Devil, and Satan" (Revelation 12:9).

✦ An interesting fact

The "fiery serpents" of Numbers 21 are called in Hebrew *seraphim* (burning serpents). In Isaiah 6, the angels who stand around God's throne are called "seraphim." The same root word! The idea of "burning" joins the torment of venom and the holy fire of God in a single word.

5.5 The First Gospel: "He Shall Bruise Thy Head"

Immediately after the sin, in the middle of the sentence of judgment, God gives a promise. Christian theologians call it "the first gospel" (*Protoevangelium*):

> "And I will put enmity between thee and the woman, and between thy seed and her seed; it shall bruise thy head, and thou shalt bruise his heel." (Genesis 3:15)

One day the woman's "seed" will crush the serpent's head, but he will be wounded in doing so. A bruised heel heals; a crushed head is final defeat. Christians see here a foreshadowing of the cross: Christ suffered, yet through that very suffering he broke the power of evil. In some old statues of the Virgin Mary in our towns you may have seen a serpent crushed beneath her feet; that is a memory of this verse.

Here there is a lovely link with Shaiva symbolism. Muyalakan, crushed beneath Nataraja's foot, is the figure of ignorance; the Lord's foot subdues it. In the Bible too, evil is finally crushed beneath a "foot." Both traditions say, "Evil will be subdued beneath God's feet."

5.6 The Psychology of Temptation: Three Steps

Read the temptation in Eden again; it is still the map of the struggle in every human heart. First step: doubt. "Hath God said?" Twisting God's word and making one doubt his goodness. "God is hiding something from you; he does not want your happiness."

Second step: denial. "Ye shall not surely die." The lie that sin has no consequences. Third step: desire. "And when the woman saw that the tree was good for food, and that it was pleasant to the eyes, and a tree to be desired to make one wise" (Genesis 3:6). The craving of the body, the craving of the eyes,

pride: John later lists these as "the lust of the flesh, and the lust of the eyes, and the pride of life" (1 John 2:16).

When Jesus was tempted in the wilderness, he faced the same three kinds of temptation: turn stone into bread (bodily need), look at the kingdoms of the world (the eyes), throw yourself from the temple pinnacle (pride). But Adam fell amid the plenty of the garden; Jesus prevailed amid the hunger of the wilderness. Each time he answered with God's word: "It is written" (Matthew 4:1–11). Where the first Adam fell, the last Adam prevailed.

5.7 The Bronze Serpent Lifted on a Pole

The most surprising serpent story in the Bible is in Numbers 21. When the Israelites murmured in the wilderness, fiery serpents bit them and many died. When Moses prayed, God gave a strange command: make a serpent of bronze and set it on a pole. "Every one that is bitten, when he looketh upon it, shall live" (Numbers 21:8). No medicine, no ritual; only looking, looking with trust.

About fourteen hundred years later Jesus reminded Nicodemus, a Jewish teacher who came to him by night, of this story:

> "And as Moses lifted up the serpent in the wilderness, even so must the Son of man be lifted up: that whosoever believeth in him should not perish, but have eternal life." (John 3:14–15)

This is the verse just before the world-famous John 3:16. Here lies a great paradox: the image of the serpent, symbol of death, becomes a symbol of healing; the cross, symbol of curse, becomes a symbol of redemption. Paul writes that "Christ hath redeemed us from the curse of the law, being made a curse for us" (Galatians 3:13).

So in Shaivism the serpent is subdued as an ornament on God's neck; in the Bible the serpent is humanity's enemy whose head must be crushed. But in both there is a common message: God is greater than the venomous power that

threatens humanity. In the Christian view that victory took place on a lifted pole, at Calvary.

5.8 The Later Story of the Bronze Serpent

The bronze serpent of Numbers has a sad sequel. About seven hundred years later, the people of Israel had kept it and begun to burn incense to it and worship it. They even gave it a name, "Nehushtan." The good king Hezekiah broke it in pieces (2 Kings 18:4).

This is an important lesson. What healed was not the bronze but the faith that looked, trusting God's promise. A sign exists to point to its goal; the sign must not itself become the goal. This is a warning for Christians too: wearing a cross around the neck or hanging one in the house is not in itself salvation; salvation is looking with faith to the one who hung on the cross.

"Look unto me, and be ye saved, all the ends of the earth" (Isaiah 45:22). A look. Those dying of snakebite had to do only one thing: turn their heads and look. That is the simplicity of the gospel.

5.9 The Heel That Crushed the Serpent's Head

The promise of Genesis 3:15 runs as a hidden thread through the whole Bible. In the Old Testament there are many scenes in which the "head" of the enemies of God's people is crushed: a woman named Jael drove a tent peg into Sisera's head (Judges 4); David struck Goliath's head with a stone and brought him down (1 Samuel 17). Each time a weak one crushes the head of a mighty enemy. Psalm 91:13 sings: "Thou shalt tread upon the lion and adder: the young lion and the dragon shalt thou trample under feet."

In the New Testament this thread is fulfilled. Jesus told his disciples, "Behold, I give unto you power to tread on serpents and scorpions, and over all the power of the enemy" (Luke 10:19). At the end of his letter to the Romans,

Paul directly echoes Genesis 3:15: "And the God of peace shall bruise Satan under your feet shortly" (Romans 16:20).

A beautiful twist is worth noticing here. In Genesis "he" (the seed of the woman) crushes the serpent's head. In Romans God crushes it under "your" feet. The victory Christ won is shared with all who are joined to him. For the Shaiva devotee who looks at Muyalakan subdued beneath Nataraja's foot, and for the Catholic devotee who looks at the serpent crushed beneath the Virgin's foot, there is one shared hope: evil will not win in the end.

For Reflection

1. When temptation comes in your life, can you recognise the three steps of "doubt, denial, desire"?
2. When talking with a Hindu friend, how will you handle serpent symbolism respectfully?
3. The bronze serpent later became an object of worship. Are there places in your spiritual life where the sign has become the goal?

Comparison

	Shaiva tradition	The Bible
Place of the serpent	Ornament on Shiva's neck (Vasuki)	Tempter in Eden (Gen 3:1)
Meaning	Subdued power, kundalini	Deception, power of evil (Rev 12:9)
Defeat of evil	Muyalakan beneath Nataraja's foot	"It shall bruise thy head" (Gen 3:15)
Healing serpent	—	The bronze serpent (Num 21:8)
Fulfilment	Danger subdued before God	The Son of Man lifted up (John 3:14)

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CHAPTER 6

The Fall and the Forgetting

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"Where art thou?" — God seeking the lost human being.

6.1 What Happened to Humanity?

All religions acknowledge one truth: humanity is not now as it ought to be. We want the good, yet we do evil. We seek peace, yet sink into anxiety. We long for love, yet get caught in selfishness. Why? Each tradition's answer to this question determines its path of liberation. Only when the disease is diagnosed correctly can the right medicine be given.

6.2 What Happened in Eden: A Slow Reading

Let us watch the story of the fall slowly, as if watching a film. The garden is abundant; fruit on every tree. But the woman stands near that one tree; the serpent speaks. Notice her reply: "Ye shall not eat of it, neither shall ye touch it, lest ye die" (Genesis 3:3). God had not said "do not touch"; she makes the command harsher herself. A view of God as strict and stingy has already crept in.

She takes and eats; "and gave also unto her husband with her; and he did eat" (3:6). Where was Adam? "With her," the verse says. He stood silent; he did not stop it. Later Paul places the responsibility for sin not on Eve but on "Adam" (Romans 5:12).

At once there is a change. Their eyes are opened, but not to the promised divine wisdom; to their nakedness. They sew fig leaves to cover themselves. Humanity's first "religion" is this: leaves by which we try to cover our own shame. Then the sound of God's footsteps in the evening breeze. The sound they once ran to with joy now frightens them. They hide among the trees.

At the end of the story comes a small but enormous act: "Unto Adam also and to his wife did the LORD God make coats of skins, and clothed them" (3:21). The leaf garment humans made will wither; for the garment of skin God made, a life had to be sacrificed. God's mercy in the midst of judgment; shame covered through sacrifice. The seed of the Bible's whole story of redemption is in this one verse.

6.3 Shaivism: The Three Impurities

Shaiva Siddhanta names the cause of the suffering of souls as the three *malas* (impurities): *anava*, *karma* and *maya*. The most basic of these is anava, the darkness that veils the soul's knowledge. The Siddhanta texts compare it to verdigris on copper, clinging to the soul without beginning. Karma is the fruit

of deeds, which causes the cycle of births. Maya is the material of body, world and experience.

Kashmir Shaivism says this even more subtly. The human being is in truth Shiva; but Shiva, by his own freedom, "conceals" himself (*tirodhana*) and appears as a limited soul. Thinking "I am this body, I am this small mind, I am lacking" is anava mala: forgetting fullness and thinking of oneself as small. Here the human problem is "forgetting." He has forgotten who he is. That is why the very name of this tradition is *Pratyabhijna*, "re-cognition."

The tradition explains this "recognising again" with a beautiful lover's analogy, which we will look at in detail a little later.

6.4 The Bible: A Broken Relationship

The Bible calls humanity's problem "sin." But sin is not only breaking rules; at its depth it is a broken relationship. Look at what happened in Eden. As soon as they ate the fruit, "the eyes of them both were opened, and they knew that they were naked." Shame was born. Then, when they heard God's voice, they "hid themselves from the presence of the LORD God amongst the trees of the garden" (Genesis 3:8). Fear was born. Then Adam blamed Eve and Eve blamed the serpent. Blame was born.

Relationship with God, with oneself, with others and with creation (the ground brought forth thorns and thistles): all four broke at once. Paul sums up the result: "by one man sin entered into the world, and death by sin" (Romans 5:12); "all have sinned, and come short of the glory of God" (Romans 3:23).

✦ Did you know?

The main Hebrew and Greek words for "sin" in the Bible (*chata*, *hamartia*) both mean "missing the mark," like an archer who shoots and misses the target. Sin is missing the goal for which humanity was created: a loving relationship with God.

6.5 The Tears of the Thiruvasagam: "Lower Than a Dog"

The Shaiva tradition does not speak of human darkness only as philosophy; it also rings in the tearful songs of the devotees. Manikkavasagar's Thiruvasagam is the best example. A Tamil proverb says, "One who does not melt at the Thiruvasagam will melt at no words." In it he calls himself again and again unworthy, "a dog," "lower than a dog," and melts at the thought that God came seeking even such a one and took him for his own.

G. U. Pope, a Christian missionary and Tamil scholar, translated the Thiruvasagam into English (1900). It is widely known that he wrote with wonder of how close its devotional experience is to that of Christian devotees. It is also said that he asked for the words "a student of Tamil" to be engraved on his grave.

The feeling "I am unworthy, but God came seeking me" recalls David's Psalm 51: "Have mercy upon me, O God, according to thy lovingkindness... my sin is ever before me... Create in me a clean heart, O God" (Psalm 51:1, 3, 10). Though the philosophy of forgetting and the theology of sin differ, the devotee's tears speak the same language.

6.6 Forgetting or Rebellion?

Here the most important difference between the two traditions appears. In Kashmir Shaivism the human condition is "forgetting": he has forgotten his true, divine identity. The remedy is "remembering," "knowing," "recognising." In Shaiva Siddhanta, anava is a beginningless impurity; the remedy is God's grace, the guidance of the guru, and spiritual discipline.

In the Bible the human condition is "rebellion": humanity rejected the Creator's love and tried to become God itself. It is not merely a wrong idea; it is a choice, a broken trust. So knowledge alone is not enough for the remedy; forgiveness is needed, reconciliation is needed. If a child forgets his home address, reminding him of it is enough. But if a son slaps his father's face and

runs away from home, he knows the address; what he needs is his father's forgiveness.

6.7 Recognising Again: The Tradition of Utpaladeva

The Pratyabhijna tradition has a beautiful analogy, generally traced to Utpaladeva's *Ishvara Pratyabhijna Karika* and its commentaries. A woman hears of a man's qualities and falls in love with him. One day he comes and stands before her; but she does not recognise him, and her heart is not satisfied. As soon as someone points out, "This is he!", great joy wells up within her. The meaning: God is always within us; when the guru's word points out "This is he," the person is set free.

This analogy recalls a scene from the Gospel. Two disciples on their way to the village of Emmaus met the risen Jesus on the road; though they walked and talked with him a long time, they did not recognise him. In the evening, when he took the bread, blessed it and broke it, "their eyes were opened, and they knew him" (Luke 24:31). They said, "Did not our heart burn within us, while he talked with us by the way, and while he opened to us the scriptures?"

In both stories the beloved is right there; recognition is the joy. The difference: in Pratyabhijna the one recognised is "your own deepest self"; on the Emmaus road the one recognised is "a risen person walking with you."

6.8 "When He Came to Himself": Where the Two Meet

Yet in Jesus' most famous parable these two ideas meet beautifully. The prodigal son took his share, went to a far country, lost everything and ended up feeding pigs. Then the Bible says, "And when he came to himself..." (Luke 15:17). He "remembered" who he was: the son of a father. This is a moment very close to *pratyabhijna*!

But the story does not end there. He rose and returned to his father. "But when he was yet a great way off, his father saw him, and had compassion, and

ran, and fell on his neck, and kissed him" (Luke 15:20). Remembering made him turn back; but what restored him was the father's running love. The first question God asked in Eden was this: "Where art thou?" (Genesis 3:9). It is God who comes searching for lost humanity. The heart of the Christian gospel is in one line: "For the Son of man is come to seek and to save that which was lost" (Luke 19:10).

6.9 Repentance: From Remembering to Returning

In the Bible the word "repentance" is very important. In Hebrew *shuv* means "to turn": one who was walking in the wrong direction stops, turns around and walks toward home. In Greek *metanoia* means "change of mind": a change in the very depth of one's thinking. Together they give a complete picture: inside, the mind changes; outside, the path changes.

Both are seen in the story of the prodigal son. "He came to himself" (change of mind); "he arose, and came to his father" (turning). The "re-cognition" of Pratyabhijna is very close to the first part. But the Bible emphasises the second part: turning toward a person.

There is a gentle truth here too: in the Bible repentance comes not as a hard duty but as an invitation. "Let the wicked forsake his way, and the unrighteous man his thoughts: and let him return unto the LORD, and he will have mercy upon him; and to our God, for he will abundantly pardon" (Isaiah 55:7). "There is joy in the presence of the angels of God over one sinner that repenteth" (Luke 15:10). A festival in heaven! When the lost son returned, the father killed the fatted calf and held a feast; music and dancing were heard. The final end of repentance is not guilt but celebration.

For Reflection

1. Is humanity's basic problem "forgetting," "rebellion," or both? What does your own experience say?
2. What are the "fig leaves" we sew today to cover our shame? (Money, position, religious rituals...)
3. The prodigal's father "ran." Do you see God as one who waits, or as one who runs to meet you?

Comparison

	Shaiva tradition	The Bible
Problem	Anava, karma, maya (three malas)	Sin: a broken relationship (Rom 3:23)
Nature	Forgetting, self-limitation, darkness	Rebellion, trying to be like God (Gen 3:5)
Result	Cycle of births	Shame, fear, death (Rom 5:12)
Remedy	Grace, wisdom, re-cognition	Forgiveness, reconciliation
Bridge	Pratyabhijna: "remembering"	"When he came to himself" (Luke 15:17)

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CHAPTER 7

The Halahala Poison and the Cross



The blue throat that received poison for the world, and the cross that bore the sin of the world.

7.1 The Churning of the Ocean

One of the most famous stories of the Indian epic and Puranic traditions is the churning of the ocean of milk (*samudra manthan*). It appears in slightly different forms in the Bhagavata Purana, the Vishnu Purana, the Mahabharata and the Shiva Purana. To obtain *amrita*, the nectar of immortality, the devas and asuras joined forces. They made Mount Mandara

the churning rod and Vasuki, king of serpents, the rope, and churned the ocean of milk. When the mountain began to sink, Vishnu took the form of a tortoise (Kurma) and bore it up.

During the churning, before the nectar, a terrible substance emerged: the *halahala* (or *alakala*) poison. Its fumes alone began to scorch the worlds. The devas and asuras fled in terror. No one could stop it. Then all of them took refuge in Lord Shiva.

7.2 The Prelude: Durvasa's Curse

Before the churning of the ocean there is a short story, told in some texts such as the Vishnu Purana. The sage Durvasa, famous for his temper, once gave Indra, king of the gods, a divine garland of flowers. Indra placed it on the head of his elephant Airavata; the elephant threw it to the ground and trampled it. The insulted sage cursed him: "May your wealth and power leave you." The gods lost their strength; the asuras defeated them.

Seeking a way to regain their lost power, the gods went to Vishnu. He advised them to churn the ocean of milk and obtain the nectar, and said they would need the help of the asuras too. So the churning of the ocean is a journey "from loss to restoration," an attempt to be freed from a curse brought on by contempt.

This prelude offers an interesting parallel with the Bible. There too a gift (the blessings of Eden) is despised; a curse comes; humanity loses power and garden. Then through the long course of history there is a longing to regain "life," "immortality." *Amrita* means "deathlessness"; the Bible's tree of life too would make one "live for ever" (Genesis 3:22). Both stories meet in the longing for a food that conquers death. Jesus said, "I am that bread of life... if any man eat of this bread, he shall live for ever" (John 6:48, 51).

7.3 Neelakanta: The One Who Took the Poison for the World

Lord Shiva took all that poison in his hand and drank it. A widespread tradition says that, because the worlds within him would perish if it reached his stomach, Uma held his throat and stopped the poison there. The place where it stayed turned blue. So he is called *Neelakanta*, "the blue-throated," and *Nanjunda Kandan*, "the one whose throat holds the poison he ate."

Tamil Shaiva devotees sang of this act again and again. The compassion of the God who exposed himself to danger to save the world melted their hearts. In the Periya Puranam, Sekkizhar sings of a devotee, Thiruneelakanta Nayanar, who all his life kept a vow sworn on this holy name of the Lord. This event is also remembered in the background of the Pradosham worship.

The heart of this story is this: the poison that came to destroy the world, which neither devas nor asuras could handle, was taken by God upon himself, and so the world lived. He did not throw it away somewhere else; he bore it in his body. That mark is still blue on his throat.

7.4 The Scene of the Churning: The Fourteen Treasures

Now imagine the scene of the churning. The colossal Mount Mandara stands as the churning rod; Vasuki, king of serpents, is wound around it as the rope. On one side the asuras hold the head; on the other the devas hold the tail. Some texts say that as they pulled, fire and smoke poured from Vasuki's mouth and wearied the asuras. When the mountain began to sink into the sea, Vishnu went beneath it as a giant tortoise (Kurma) and bore it up.

Poets sing that the churning went on for a thousand years. One by one wonders rose from the ocean of milk; tradition lists them as the "fourteen treasures" (the list varies somewhat from text to text): Kamadhenu, the wish-granting cow; Uchchaihshravas, the white horse; Airavata, the white elephant;

the kalpaka tree; the Kaustubha gem; the goddess Lakshmi; the moon; and finally Dhanvantari, the divine physician, bearing the pot of nectar.

But in the midst of these marvels, before the nectar, that horror emerged: the dark, foaming, seething halahala. In its heat the ocean boiled; the bodies of the gods were scorched; the three worlds choked. A deep truth lies hidden here: before obtaining the nectar, one must pass through the poison. Before deathlessness, the challenge of death. Unless someone takes that poison, the nectar will reach no one.

7.5 The Suffering Servant: Isaiah 53

Now, with the same heart that meditates on Shiva's blue throat, let us open the book of the prophet Isaiah, whose writing is traditionally dated from the eighth century BC. Chapter fifty-three describes a mysterious "Servant of the Lord":

> "Surely he hath borne our griefs, and carried our sorrows... But he was wounded for our transgressions, he was bruised for our iniquities: the chastisement of our peace was upon him; and with his stripes we are healed. All we like sheep have gone astray; we have turned every one to his own way; and the LORD hath laid on him the iniquity of us all." (Isaiah 53:4–6)

Reading these lines, a startling parallel with the story of the blue throat appears. Like a poison that destroys the world, there is the "iniquity" of humanity, which no one can bear. One person takes it on himself. He is wounded; we are healed.

✦ Did you know?

The Pradosham worship, held twice a month in the Shiva temples of Tamil Nadu (in the evening, on the thirteenth lunar day), is traditionally linked with the event in which Lord Shiva swallowed the halahala poison and saved the world. Just as Christians observe every Friday in memory of the cross! Both traditions remember "God's sacrifice" again and again in a regular cycle of time.

7.6 The Poison Borne on the Cross

The New Testament recognises Isaiah's servant in Jesus Christ (Acts 8:32–35). The apostle Peter writes:

> "Who his own self bare our sins in his own body on the tree, that we, being dead to sins, should live unto righteousness: by whose stripes ye were healed." (1 Peter 2:24)

"In his own body." As Shiva held the poison in his throat, Christ bore sin in his body. Paul says it even more startlingly: "For he hath made him to be sin for us, who knew no sin; that we might be made the righteousness of God in him" (2 Corinthians 5:21). The one who had no sin took upon himself all the poison of the world.

When Jesus prayed in the garden of Gethsemane, he said, "O my Father, if it be possible, let this cup pass from me: nevertheless not as I will, but as thou wilt" (Matthew 26:39). The "cup" he had to drink! Is it not amazing that the picture of God holding a cup of poison appears in both traditions?

7.7 Likeness and Difference: Stopped at the Throat, Carried to Death

But the differences in this comparison are just as important; they show the uniqueness of the Christian gospel.

First, the nature of the poison. The halahala is a destructive force that arises in the cosmos; though devas and asuras caused it, it is not their "guilt." The Bible's "poison" is our own sin: "our transgressions," "our iniquities." What Christ bore was not the result of an accident, but our guilt and its just penalty.

Second, the end of the poison. Uma's hand stopped the poison at the throat; Shiva was not harmed by it. At Calvary no one stopped the poison. Jesus drank it fully, all the way to death. He cried, "My God, my God, why hast thou forsaken me?" (Matthew 27:46). Then he said, "It is finished" (John 19:30), and bowed his head. On the third day he rose, conquering death. The poison did not defeat him; he defeated the poison.

Third, the mark. On Shiva's throat the blue remains. On the risen Jesus the scars of the nails and the spear remained in his hands and side (John 20:27). Revelation describes him as "a Lamb as it had been slain" (5:6). In both traditions, the mark of sacrifice remains forever on the body of the saviour.

7.8 The Scene of the Cross: Six Hours at Calvary

Now let us go to Calvary. Friday, about nine in the morning. A whole night of trials, mockery and blows. A back torn by the whips of Roman soldiers. A crown of thorns on his head. When he fell, unable to carry his own cross, Simon of Cyrene was compelled to carry it. At the place called Golgotha, "the place of a skull," nails were driven into his hands and feet.

His first word on the cross was not a curse but a prayer: "Father, forgive them; for they know not what they do" (Luke 23:34). For those who were killing him! From noon until three o'clock "there was darkness over all the land"

(Matthew 27:45). The hour when all the poison of the world came down upon him. At the height of that darkness came the cry: "Eli, Eli, lama sabachthani?": My God, my God, why hast thou forsaken me?

Then he said, "I thirst." Sour wine was given him. Having received it he said, "It is finished"; not a sigh of defeat but a proclamation of victory. In Greek, *tetelestai*: the debt is paid in full. Finally, crying with a loud voice, "Father, into thy hands I commend my spirit" (Luke 23:46), he gave up his spirit. At that moment the veil of the temple was torn in two from top to bottom. The barrier between God and humanity was removed. Not the gate of Kailash, but the gate of Eden opened.

As in the story of the blue throat, here too one drank the cup of poison for all. But here no mother's hand held his throat to stop it; his mother Mary stood weeping at the foot of the cross. He drank to the last drop.

7.9 To the Heart That Sings of the Blue Throat

The heart of a Shaiva devotee who melts at the thought of the God who took poison for the world already knows the worth of sacrifice. To that heart the Christian gospel wishes to say, very gently: that sacrifice was not only a story of myth, but happened on a particular day in history, in the time of Pontius Pilate, on a hill outside Jerusalem; and it happened not only for the gods or for the good, but for sinners.

"But God commendeth his love toward us, in that, while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us" (Romans 5:8). The hands that worship the blue throat and the eyes that look upon the cross long toward the same truth: what we cannot bear, God himself must bear. The Christian faith says: he did.

7.10 The Cup: An Image Shared by Two Traditions

The image of the "cup" has deep meaning in the Bible. The Old Testament prophets pictured God's judgment as a "cup of wrath": "For in the hand of the LORD there is a cup, and the wine is red; it is full of mixture" (Psalm 75:8); Jeremiah 25:15 uses the same image. The just consequence of sin, the bitter cup humans must drink.

That is what Jesus meant in Gethsemane by "this cup." Not fear of ordinary death, but the agony of having to drink himself the judgment for the sin of the world. That is why his soul was "exceeding sorrowful, even unto death"; his sweat fell to the ground "as it were great drops of blood" (Luke 22:44).

The foaming halahala and the foaming cup of wrath! Both traditions use the same image: a liquid of destruction humans cannot bear, which God himself drinks. Then the cup changes. At the Last Supper Jesus took a cup and gave it to his disciples, saying, "This is my blood" (Matthew 26:28). Because he drank the cup of wrath, we receive the cup of salvation: "I will take the cup of salvation, and call upon the name of the LORD" (Psalm 116:13). He drank the poison; for us, the nectar.

7.11 A Meditation Before the Cross

Let us close this chapter with a short meditation. Sit in a quiet place. Close your eyes and first recall the scene of the ocean of milk: the dark poison boiling up, the gods fleeing, the world frozen in fear. Now connect that poison with your own life: the harsh words you have spoken, the enmity you have held, jealousy, caste hatred, greed, the secret wrongs you have told no one. These are poisons that slowly scorch you and those around you.

Now think of Calvary. One person receives all that poison in his body. He does not accuse you; he prays, "Father, forgive them." Say Isaiah's words slowly, putting yourself into them: "He was wounded for my transgressions; he was bruised for my iniquities; with his stripes I am healed."

A hymn written in 1707 by the English poet Isaac Watts is sung all over the world on Good Friday: "When I survey the wondrous cross." Its last lines say: "Were the whole realm of nature mine, that were a present far too small; love so amazing, so divine, demands my soul, my life, my all." The Thevaram poets who sang of the blue throat and the Christian poets who sang of the cross realised the same truth: the only fitting answer to sacrificial love is our whole life.

For Reflection

1. In the Neelakanta story the poison is a cosmic destructive force; at the cross the poison is "our sin." How does this difference touch you?
2. Does the truth of the churning, "poison before nectar," give any meaning to the sufferings of your life?
3. The first word from the cross was "Father, forgive them." Whom do you need to forgive?

Comparison

	Shaiva tradition	The Bible
Poison	Halahala: cosmic destruction	Sin: our transgressions (Isa 53:5)
Who took it	Lord Shiva, Neelakanta	Jesus Christ, the Suffering Servant
How	Held and stopped at the throat	Bore it in his body (1 Pet 2:24)
Result	World saved from destruction	Death, resurrection, forgiveness
Lasting mark	The blue throat	The scars (John 20:27)

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CHAPTER 8

The Third Eye and the Light of the World

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The light sought within, and the light that came into the world.

8.1 The Eye on the Forehead

One of Lord Shiva's most distinctive marks is the third eye in the middle of his forehead. He is called *Mukkannan*, *Tryambaka*, "the three-eyed one." The Thiruvilaiyadal story tells that the poet Nakkeerar argued with Shiva himself, saying, "Even if you open your forehead eye, a fault is still a fault"; to this day that line rings on Tamil lips as a cry for honesty.

According to the Puranas, when Manmatha (Kama), the god of love, shot his flower-arrow to break Shiva's meditation, Shiva opened his third eye and Manmatha was burned to ashes. Kalidasa's *Kumarasambhava* sings this story as poetry. Its symbolic meaning: when the inner light opens, desire and illusion burn to ash. The holy ash (*vibhuti*) that Shiva's devotees wear on their foreheads recalls that ash, the impermanence of all that perishes.

8.2 The Burning of Kama: The Full Story

Let us look in detail at the most famous story of the third eye. An asura named Tarakasura performed severe penance and won the boon, "Death only at the hands of Shiva's son." At that time Lord Shiva, grieving the loss of his first wife Sati, had forgotten the world and was in deep meditation. Without a son of Shiva no one could defeat Taraka. Parvati, born as the daughter of Himavan, king of the mountains (Sati reborn), was serving Shiva; but Shiva did not open his eyes.

The gods sent Manmatha, the god of love. Spring came; flowers bloomed; cuckoos sang. Manmatha fitted a flower-arrow to his sugarcane bow and shot it at Shiva's heart. His meditation broken, Shiva angrily opened his forehead eye. In the fire that came from it Manmatha was reduced to ashes in an instant. His wife Rati wept and wailed.

The story did not end there. Parvati resolved to win Shiva not by beauty but by severe penance. To test the firmness of her penance, Shiva himself came as a young ascetic and spoke scornfully of himself; she did not waver. Pleased, Shiva married her; Murugan was born to them and defeated Taraka. Some traditions say that at Rati's plea Manmatha was given life in a bodiless form. In Tamil Nadu the story of Murugan's birth is sung at length in the Kanda Puranam.

The spiritual meaning of this story: unrestrained desire burns to ash in the gaze of wisdom; but love purified by penance reaches God and gives birth to new life.

8.3 The Ajna Chakra of Yoga

In the yoga tradition the point between the eyebrows is called the *ajna chakra*. Yogis teach that focusing attention there in meditation is a way to experience the inner light. The *pottu* and *tilak* worn on the forehead recall this point. In recent times some have linked this "third eye" with a small organ in the middle of the brain called the pineal gland; it is a scientific fact that this gland secretes the hormone melatonin according to the cycle of light and dark. But it must be said honestly that its being the spiritual "third eye" has not been proven by science; it is only a metaphorical link.

Either way, the message of this symbol is clear: a human being needs not only outward eyes but inner sight. Eyes that see only the world are not enough; we need an eye that sees the truth.

8.4 "The Light of the Body Is the Eye"

Jesus too said a surprising thing about the eye:

> "The light of the body is the eye: if therefore thine eye be single, thy whole body shall be full of light. But if thine eye be evil, thy whole body shall be full of darkness." (Matthew 6:22–23)

The Greek word translated "single" is *haplous*, which also means "undivided," "sincere." Interestingly, this verse comes in the middle of teaching about the love of money ("Lay not up for yourselves treasures upon earth"). An eye fixed on one goal, God, fills the heart with light; a divided eye that tries to look at money and God at once brings darkness. As Shiva's forehead eye burned desire, the "single eye" Jesus speaks of brings freedom from greed. Both traditions link inner sight with freedom from desire.

Another beautiful line of the Bible: "For God, who commanded the light to shine out of darkness, hath shined in our hearts, to give the light of the

knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ" (2 Corinthians 4:6). The first light of creation and the inner light of the heart come from the same God.

✦ A scientific note

The pineal gland is a small, rice-grain-sized organ in the middle of the brain. It secretes the hormone melatonin and regulates the sleep–wake cycle. Some reptiles (for example the tuatara) have a light-sensing "parietal eye" on top of the head, which is related to the pineal system. The seventeenth-century philosopher Descartes regarded the pineal gland as "the seat of the soul." But there is no scientific evidence that it is the spiritual "third eye"; that is only a metaphorical link.

8.5 A River of Light: Light's Journey Through the Bible

The Bible can also be read as the story of light. The first word of creation is "Let there be light" (Genesis 1:3). When thick darkness covered Egypt for three days, "all the children of Israel had light in their dwellings" (Exodus 10:23). The pillar of fire in the wilderness. The lampstand that never went out in the tabernacle. When Moses came down after speaking with God, "the skin of his face shone"; because the people were afraid to see it, he put a veil over his face (Exodus 34:29–35).

David sang: "The LORD is my light and my salvation; whom shall I fear?" (Psalm 27:1); "Thy word is a lamp unto my feet, and a light unto my path" (Psalm 119:105). Isaiah foretold: "The people that walked in darkness have seen a great light" (Isaiah 9:2). Matthew links this verse with the beginning of Jesus' ministry in Galilee (Matthew 4:16).

On the mount of transfiguration Jesus' "face did shine as the sun, and his raiment was white as the light" (Matthew 17:2). Moses' face shone with reflected light; Jesus' face shone from within. Finally, in the new Jerusalem: "And the city had no need of the sun, neither of the moon, to shine in it: for the

glory of God did lighten it, and the Lamb is the light thereof" (Revelation 21:23).

Placing this river of light beside Shiva's form as *jyoti* (the beacon of Annamalai, Manikkavasagar's cry "O Light, O Flame"), it becomes clear that experiencing God as "light" is one of humanity's deepest and most common experiences.

8.6 "I Am the Light of the World"

But Jesus did not only speak about the eye; he declared himself to be the light. Jewish tradition says that great lamps were lit in the Jerusalem temple during the Feast of Tabernacles; in that setting he said:

> "I am the light of the world: he that followeth me shall not walk in darkness, but shall have the light of life." (John 8:12)

In the next chapter he opens the eyes of a man born blind (John 9). He mixes clay and spreads it on the man's eyes, as if the creating hands that formed Adam from the dust were at work again! That blind man not only received outward sight; in the end, looking at Jesus, he received inner sight too, saying, "Lord, I believe."

8.7 Light Rising from Within, or Light Coming In?

Here again the difference between the two paths appears. In the Shaiva and yoga traditions the light is already within; through meditation and discipline a person must open it. In Kashmir Shaivism that inner light is Shiva's own light.

In the Bible a human being was made to reflect light, but has been darkened by sin. Light does not rise from within him; it comes from outside, from God, as "the true Light, which lighteth every man that cometh into the world" (John 1:9). But once it enters, the person also becomes light: "Ye are the light of the

world" (Matthew 5:14). The moon does not shine by itself; when it faces the sun, it lights up the night. The Christian is like that moon.

8.8 The Witness of the Man Whose Eyes Were Opened

The story in John chapter 9 is a little drama. Seeing a man blind from birth, the disciples asked: "Master, who did sin, this man, or his parents, that he was born blind?" The same question is asked in our society: "sin from a past birth," "fate," "karma." This question still oppresses the disabled and the poor.

Jesus' answer is revolutionary: "Neither hath this man sinned, nor his parents: but that the works of God should be made manifest in him" (John 9:3). Instead of blaming, he heals. He mixed clay, spread it on the man's eyes and said, "Go, wash in the pool of Siloam." He went, washed, and came back seeing.

But the real test came afterwards. The religious leaders questioned him and threatened him; his parents, afraid, kept their distance. He gave a simple testimony: "One thing I know, that, whereas I was blind, now I see" (9:25). He was thrown out of the synagogue. Then Jesus went looking for him and found him. He worshipped him, saying, "Lord, I believe." His outer eyes opened at the pool; his inner eyes opened when he met Jesus. This is the Bible's "third eye."

8.9 Do Not Hide the Lamp Under a Bushel

A simple parable Jesus told his disciples: "Neither do men light a candle, and put it under a bushel, but on a candlestick; and it giveth light unto all that are in the house" (Matthew 5:15). Think of the clay lamp set in the wall niche of our grandmothers' houses. Only because it was set high did its light spread through the whole house.

The meaning of this parable is that inner light should not remain only a private experience. The calm found in meditation and the comfort found in

prayer are good; but they must become light in the dark corners of our society. The prophet Isaiah says what true fasting is: "Is it not to deal thy bread to the hungry, and that thou bring the poor that are cast out to thy house?... Then shall thy light break forth as the morning" (Isaiah 58:7–8).

This verse comes to my mind when I see the children studying under a single small electric bulb in our trust's evening classes in Thoothukudi. Those who have received the light of the world must kindle the light of education in the lives of poor children. Shiva's forehead eye burned desire; Christ's light should set us burning with love.

For Reflection

1. Do you have the "single" (undivided) eye Jesus spoke of? What second goal divides your sight?
2. What answer does John 9:3 give to the view that blames sufferers for "sin in a past birth" or "fate"?
3. Like the moon, what light do you reflect? What do the people around you see in you?

Comparison

	Shaiva tradition	The Bible
Symbol	Shiva's forehead eye	"The light of the body is the eye" (Matt 6:22)
Victory over desire	The gaze that burned Manmatha	A single, undivided eye
Source of light	Shiva's light already within	Light that came into the world (John 1:9)
The way	Meditation, ajna chakra	"He that followeth me" (John 8:12)
Result	Wisdom, burning of illusion	"Ye are the light of the world" (Matt 5:14)

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CHAPTER 9

Self-Realisation or Relationship?

✦



The knowledge "I am He," and the cry "Abba, Father!"

9.1 What Is Liberation?

All the parallels we have seen so far finally lead to one question: what is humanity's ultimate goal? The Hindu traditions call it *moksha* or *mukti*: release from the cycle of births. Shaivism calls it "attaining Shiva," "reaching the true home." The Bible calls it "salvation," "eternal life." Jesus defined eternal life like this: "And this is life eternal, that they might know thee the only true God,

and Jesus Christ, whom thou hast sent" (John 17:3). Notice: here too there is "knowing"! But it is knowing a person, knowing in a relationship.

9.2 "Shivoham": I Am Shiva

In Kashmir Shaivism liberation is not reaching a new place; it is recognising again a truth that already exists. The first sutra of the *Shiva Sutras*, which tradition says were revealed to Vasugupta, is "*Chaitanyam atma*" — consciousness is the self. That consciousness is Shiva's consciousness. To realise in experience "I am Shiva" (*Shivoham*) is liberation. Meditation, mantra and the guru's grace (*shaktipata*) help in this. Tradition says that the *Vijnana Bhairava Tantra* teaches 112 methods of meditation for this purpose.

Tamil Shaiva Siddhanta makes an important distinction here. According to it, the liberated soul "merges inseparably" with Shiva but does not become Shiva himself. Though united, like salt dissolved in water, the soul does not wholly lose its distinctness; it enjoys God's bliss. Siddhanta explains this as *advaita* (non-duality) in its own special sense. This subtlety comes closer to the biblical idea of "relationship" than Kashmir Shaivism does.

Closer still is Tirumular's famous verse, here in paraphrase: the ignorant say love and Shiva are two; none know that love itself is Shiva; once they know that love is Shiva, they abide as love, as Shiva.

> "Love is Shiva" (*Anbe Sivam*) — Tirumantiram

Read beside the verse "God is love" (1 John 4:8), this one line will make any reader stop and think.

9.3 Manikkavasagar's Encounter at Tirupperunturai

In the Shaiva tradition there is no better example of the experience of being claimed by grace than the life of Manikkavasagar. According to tradition he was

a minister of the Pandya king. When he set out with a great sum the king had given him to buy horses, at Tirupperunturai (today's Avudaiyarkoil) he met a guru seated beneath a kurundha tree. In that very moment his heart melted; he fell at the guru's feet. Tradition holds that the one who came as the guru was Lord Shiva himself. He spent all the money he had brought on temple work, and accepted the king's punishment.

There is an important feature in this story: Manikkavasagar did not go seeking God; God came seeking him. What he sings of again and again in wonder in the Thiruvasagam is this: the Lord "took him for his own," unworthy as he was.

This recalls a scene from the New Testament. A Jewish scholar named Saul set out for Damascus to persecute Christians. On the way a great light from heaven shone round about him; he heard a voice, "Saul, Saul, why persecutest thou me?" (Acts 9:4). That encounter changed him completely; he became Paul, who later wrote, "By grace are ye saved." In both stories the seeker is God; the one claimed is a human being; and the result is a song of gratitude that overflows for a lifetime.

9.4 Grace: A Gift That Cannot Be Earned

The Bible's path of liberation is contained in one word: grace.

> "For by grace are ye saved through faith; and that not of yourselves: it is the gift of God: not of works, lest any man should boast." (Ephesians 2:8–9)

This is not opposed to human effort; but effort is not the "cause" of salvation; it is its "result." A mother loves her child before it learns to walk; because the child is secure in that love, it dares to walk. Meditation, prayer and good living are part of Christian life; but they are not to earn God's love, rather a response to love already received.

The Shaiva tradition also knows the idea of *arul* (grace) deeply. In Shaiva Siddhanta the soul cannot be freed from the impurities without God's grace. Manikkavasagar sings, "By his grace alone I bow at his feet": even to worship God, his grace is needed! Here there is a beautiful closeness between grace and *arul*. The difference lies in how, through whom, and at what cost that grace comes: in Christianity it comes at the cost of the cross, through a historical person.

✦ An interesting fact

The word "Abba" (Aramaic אַבָּא) appears untranslated in the New Testament in only three places: Jesus' prayer in Gethsemane (Mark 14:36), Romans 8:15 and Galatians 4:6. That authors writing in Greek left this one word untranslated may be because no other word could carry its intimacy. In Tamil it comes naturally as *appa*!

9.5 The Monkey and the Kitten: Effort and Grace

There is an interesting debate in the history of Indian theology; it took place in the Vaishnava tradition, but it is very fitting for this chapter. What is the human part in receiving God's grace? One side used the analogy of the "baby monkey": the young one must cling tightly to its mother by itself; that is, human effort is needed too. The other side used the analogy of the "kitten": the mother cat carries her kitten in her mouth; the kitten does nothing; all is God's grace.

These analogies come very close to Christian theology. "By grace are ye saved through faith" leans toward the "kitten" side: salvation is entirely God's gift. But the same Paul says in the next verse, "For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus unto good works" (Ephesians 2:10). After being carried like a kitten, it learns to walk and to run!

Shaiva Siddhanta too discusses the same question deeply through concepts such as *iruvinaioppu* (the balancing of deeds), *malaparipaka* (the ripening of impurity) and *shaktinipata* (the descent of grace): God's grace descends when

the soul is ripe. That this debate about grace and effort exists in both traditions shows that both have grasped the truth that humans cannot save themselves.

9.6 "Abba, Father!": Adoption as Children

In Shaivism the liberated soul becomes one with Shiva. In the Bible the redeemed person becomes God's "child":

> "For ye have not received the spirit of bondage again to fear; but ye have received the Spirit of adoption, whereby we cry, Abba, Father." (Romans 8:15)

"Abba" is the intimate word with which a child calls his father in Aramaic, the language Jesus spoke. In Tamil too, *appa* has the same sound and the same feeling! The right to call the God who made the universe "Abba," like a little child. "Behold, what manner of love the Father hath bestowed upon us, that we should be called the sons of God" (1 John 3:1).

This is the difference between "oneness" and "relationship." In oneness the "I" dissolves; in relationship the "I" meets a "Thou," loves and is loved. Jesus told his disciples, "Henceforth I call you not servants... but I have called you friends" (John 15:15). Not becoming one with God, but becoming God's friend and child: that is the glory the Bible shows.

9.7 A Respectful Conclusion

In stating this difference one thing must be stressed: the longing of the sages who seek oneness and the tears of the devotees who sang "Love is Shiva" are worthy of respect. They were in a genuine search for God. When the apostle Paul spoke to the people of Athens, he quoted their own poets and said, "For in him we live, and move, and have our being" (Acts 17:28). He honoured their

search; then he proclaimed that this search finds its fulfilment in a person. This book is written in the same spirit.

9.8 A Child of God: A Thoothukudi Story

Whenever I hear the word "adoption," one incident comes to mind. A boy who came to our trust's evening class had lost both parents and grew up in a relative's house almost like a servant. One day after class he asked hesitantly, "Anna, can I also become somebody's child?" That question still echoes in my heart.

In the Roman world of Paul's time adoption was a legal act. The adopted child had all his old debts cancelled, received a new name, and became the full heir of the new family, with rights equal to a natural-born child. Using this picture Paul writes: "And if children, then heirs; heirs of God, and joint-heirs with Christ" (Romans 8:17).

One who lived as a slave becomes the king's son! "Wherefore thou art no more a servant, but a son" (Galatians 4:7). To everyone who feels like "nobody" because of caste, poverty or orphanhood, the gospel says: the God of the universe calls you "my child." I cannot forget the light I saw in that boy's eyes when I read this verse to him.

9.9 The Final State: Dissolving, or Seeing Face to Face?

How do the two traditions describe the final state of liberation? In Kashmir Shaivism it is *purna ahanta*: the full "I"-consciousness, the limited small "I" expanding into Shiva's infinite "I," like a wave realising that it is the ocean. In Shaiva Siddhanta it is the soul delighting in God's bliss while keeping its distinctness.

The Bible describes the final state as "seeing face to face": "For now we see through a glass, darkly; but then face to face: now I know in part; but then shall I know even as also I am known" (1 Corinthians 13:12). Notice how the

Kashmiri sages' "mirror" image appears again here! But for Paul the mirror is our present, partial knowledge; at the end there is a direct meeting with no mirror at all.

John goes a step further: "We know that, when he shall appear, we shall be like him; for we shall see him as he is" (1 John 3:2). "We shall be like him," but not "we shall become him." This is the subtle yet deep difference between the longing to become one with Shiva and the hope of being wholly transformed into God's likeness. In one the lover dissolves into the beloved; in the other the lovers rejoice for ever, looking at each other face to face.

For Reflection

1. Are you seeking God, or do you feel that God has come seeking you?
2. The "baby monkey" or the "kitten"? What do you think your part in salvation is?
3. Is it easy for you to call God "Abba, Father"? Why?

Comparison

	Shaiva tradition	The Bible
Goal	Moksha, attaining Shiva	Eternal life (John 17:3)
The way	Wisdom, meditation, the guru's grace	Grace and faith (Eph 2:8)
God's part	Arul, shaktipata	Grace at the cost of the cross
Final state	Shivoham / inseparable union	Child, friend (Rom 8:15; John 15:15)
Common ground	"Love is Shiva" (Tirumantiram)	"God is love" (1 John 4:8)

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CHAPTER 10

The Last Adam: From Kailash to Calvary

✦



From the garden the first Adam lost to the gate the last Adam opened.

10.1 Looking Back on the Journey

At the beginning of this book we spoke of two mountains. Now let us look back on the journey. At the beginning both traditions met in the words "Word" and "light"; but we saw that the Bible's Word is a person. Adiyogi and Adam played different roles in the human story. Kailash and Eden are God's dwelling places; but Eden was lost. Ardhanarishvara and "one flesh" spoke of

the unity of man and woman. The serpent is an ornament in one and an enemy in the other. Humanity's problem is forgetting in one and a broken relationship in the other. The blue throat and the cross showed God taking poison for the world. The third eye and the light of the world spoke of inner sight. Self-realisation and relationship showed two paths of liberation.

What thread ties all these together in one book? Paul says it in one line.

10.2 Two Adams

> "And so it is written, The first man Adam was made a living soul; the last Adam was made a quickening spirit." (1 Corinthians 15:45)

The Bible sees the whole of human history as the story of two men. "For as in Adam all die, even so in Christ shall all be made alive" (1 Corinthians 15:22). "For as by one man's disobedience many were made sinners, so by the obedience of one shall many be made righteous" (Romans 5:19).

Place the two Adams side by side:

- The first Adam was tested in a garden and fell; the last Adam prevailed in a garden called Gethsemane, saying, "Thy will be done."
- The first Adam brought death through the fruit of a tree; the last Adam brought life by hanging on a tree (the cross).
- The first Adam tried to "be as God"; the last Adam, "being in the form of God, thought it not robbery to be equal with God: but made himself of no reputation" and became man (Philippians 2:6–7).
- For the first Adam, Eve was taken from his side; when the side of the last Adam was pierced with a spear, blood and water came out (John 19:34). The church fathers saw in this the birth of the church, his "bride."
- The curse that fell on the first Adam was "thorns and thistles"; the last Adam bore a crown of thorns on his head.

- The first Adam was driven out of the garden; the last Adam opened the gate of paradise to a thief.

10.3 Romans 5: The Account of Two Men

The fifth chapter of Paul's letter to the Romans shows the whole of human history like an account book. On one side Adam; on the other Christ. On Adam's side: one trespass, sin, death, condemnation. On Christ's side: one act of obedience, grace, righteousness, life.

But Paul does not set them as equals. "But not as the offence, so also is the free gift" (Romans 5:15). Grace does not merely balance sin; it surpasses it: "where sin abounded, grace did much more abound" (5:20). Christ gives back more than Adam lost. Adam lost a garden; Christ gives a whole city, the new Jerusalem. Adam stained the image of God; in Christ humans are "conformed to the image of his Son" (Romans 8:29).

That is why in the ancient church a daring line was sung in the Easter night hymn: "O happy fault (*O felix culpa*), that won for us so great a Redeemer!" It does not mean the fall was good; it means that God's love is greater than the fall.

10.4 The Longing of Adiyogi and the Answer of the Last Adam

Now let us return to the title of this book. The symbol of Adiyogi shows a deep longing within humanity: the longing that God himself would come down and show humanity the way. The blue throat shows another longing: that God himself would bear the poison humans cannot bear. The song "Love is Shiva" shows a third longing: that God's very essence would be love.

The witness of the Christian faith is this: these longings are not in vain. They point to a truth. God really did come down: "the Word was made flesh, and dwelt among us." He really did bear the poison: "who his own self bare our

sins in his own body on the tree." God's essence really is love: "For God so loved the world, that he gave his only begotten Son, that whosoever believeth in him should not perish, but have everlasting life" (John 3:16).

I do not say this to belittle anyone's tradition. It is an invitation. To hearts that long toward Kailash, a voice calls from Calvary.

✦ Did you know?

The name Calvary comes from the Latin *calvaria* (skull); in Aramaic, *Golgotha*. There is an old Christian tradition (mentioned by early fathers such as Origen) that Adam's skull was buried beneath Calvary and that Christ's blood flowed down onto it and redeemed him. That is why in many old paintings of the crucifixion a skull is painted at the foot of the cross. This is not history but a symbolic tradition; yet it beautifully expresses this book's idea that "the first Adam and the last Adam meet on the same mountain."

10.5 The Garden of the Last Adam: Resurrection Morning

One of the most beautiful hidden touches in the Bible is on resurrection morning. John notes specifically that the tomb where Jesus was buried was "in a garden" (John 19:41). Early on the first day of the week, while it was still dark, Mary Magdalene came to the tomb. The stone was rolled away; the body was gone. She stood weeping.

Then someone stood behind her and asked, "Woman, why weepest thou? whom seekest thou?" "She, supposing him to be the gardener..." (John 20:15). Then he called her by name: "Mary!" In that one word she recognised him: "Rabboni!" (Teacher).

Many Christian thinkers point out that her supposing him to be "the gardener" was not wrong. The first Adam was placed in the garden of Eden "to dress it and to keep it"; he failed. The last Adam stands alive in a garden on the first day of the week, the first day of the new creation: the true gardener of the new Eden. In Eden God called to the hiding man, "Where art thou?" In this

garden the Risen One calls a weeping woman by her name. In a story where people blamed a woman for bringing sin, the first witness of the resurrection is a woman!

Our journey that came from Kailash to Calvary continues from Calvary to this garden. There every reader's name is called.

10.6 The Invitation of Calvary

> "Come unto me, all ye that labour and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest." (Matthew 11:28)

This invitation does not tell you to climb a mountain, or to labour through birth after birth, or to be born into a particular caste or race. Only one word: "Come." He who came down from the mountain for those who cannot climb it calls with the same voice in the fisherman's hut of Thoothukudi, in the last street of the village, and in the great mansion of the city.

"Behold, I stand at the door, and knock: if any man hear my voice, and open the door, I will come in to him, and will sup with him, and he with me" (Revelation 3:20). The same God who searched in Eden, asking "Where art thou?", still knocks at the door today.

10.7 Guidelines for Dialogue

Christian readers of this book may wish to talk with their Shaiva friends. For that I offer a few guidelines. First, listen. Before speaking, ask your friend what he finds most beautiful in his faith. Respect the light in his eyes when he says, "Love is Shiva."

Second, be accurate. When speaking about Shaivism, speak from its own texts, not from rumours or caricatures. Words like "What you worship is the devil" close the door of the gospel. Peter said, "Be ready always to give an answer

to every man that asketh you a reason of the hope that is in you with meekness and fear" (1 Peter 3:15). "Meekness" and "reverence": do not forget these two words.

Third, begin with the similarities, and state the differences honestly. Saying all religions are the same insults both traditions; each has its uniqueness. Fourth, live it out. When you help the poor man on your street, when you eat with everyone regardless of caste, your life will speak of Calvary more than your words. "Let your light so shine before men, that they may see your good works, and glorify your Father which is in heaven" (Matthew 5:16).

10.8 Conclusion: A Path Between Two Mountains

On the cover of this book there is a snow mountain on one side, a hill with three crosses on the other, and a golden path between them. That path is the reader's path. If a Shaiva reader, finishing this book, feels that his tradition has been spoken of with respect, and at the same time begins to look at the cross of Calvary with new eyes, this book has achieved its purpose. If a Christian reader learns to converse with his Shaiva neighbour with love and understanding, without scorning his faith, this book has achieved its purpose.

The story that began in the first Adam is fulfilled in the last Adam. The lost garden blossoms as a new garden; there the river of life flows and the tree of life stands, and "there shall be no more curse" (Revelation 22:3). This journey from Kailash to Calvary continues from Calvary to the new Eden. My prayer is that you too will join that journey.

10.9 A Prayer for the Reader

Before I close this book, I want to write a prayer for each one who has read it. Whether you are a Christian, a Shaiva, or someone with no faith at all, try saying these words once in your heart:

"O Word who was in the beginning, O Light that shines in the darkness, O you who made me: remind me where I came from. I have forgotten the garden I lost, the evenings I walked with you. You know the poison I have drunk in my life, and the poison I have given to others. You who bore that poison at Calvary, forgive me. Give me the courage to answer your voice, which comes seeking me today asking, 'Where art thou?', with 'Here I am.' Receive me as your child; give me the right to call you 'Abba.' Let my life be a light to others. Amen."

I welcome with love your questions, your comments, and even your disagreements about this book. True dialogue begins with questions. To my brothers and sisters who love Kailash, and to my brothers and sisters who love Calvary: thank you for walking with me on this journey. We will talk more; we will keep seeking together.

For Reflection

1. Of the comparisons between the first Adam and the last Adam, which touched you most?
2. The Risen One called Mary by her name. If he called you by your name today, what would you answer?
3. Which chapter of this book would you most like to share first with a Shaiva friend? Why?

Comparison

	The first Adam	The last Adam
Garden	Fell in Eden	Prevailed in Gethsemane
Tree	Death through the fruit	Life through the cross
Aim	Tried to be like God	Made himself of no reputation (Phil 2:7)
Head	Thorns and thistles (curse)	Crown of thorns
End	Driven from the garden	“Today in paradise” (Luke 23:43)



References

The primary texts used in this book, and secondary works for those who wish to read further:

The Bible

- The Holy Bible, Tamil Union Version (Bible Society of India) for the Tamil edition; English quotations in this edition follow the King James Version, lightly modernised in places.

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With gratitude,

Neelam P.J. Pradeep Jesudas, B.Th

Author

Two Mountains... One Search!

Snow-covered Kailash. Calvary, where three crosses stand. Thousands of kilometres apart, yet both seek the answer to one question: where did humanity come from, where did it lose its way, and how will it return to God?

Adiyogi and Adam, the Ganga and the rivers of Eden, Ardhanarishvara and "one flesh," the serpent on Shiva's neck and the serpent of Eden, the halahala poison and the cross: placing astonishing parallels side by side, this book shows with respect and depth where the two traditions meet and where they part.

Speaking in the very words of the Tirumantiram, the Thevaram, the wisdom of Kashmir Shaivism and the Holy Bible, this comparative study leads the reader toward the good news that what the first Adam lost, "the last Adam" has restored.

"The first man Adam was made a living soul; the last Adam was made a quickening spirit."

— 1 Corinthians 15:45

Neelam P.J. Pradeep Jesudas, B.Th

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